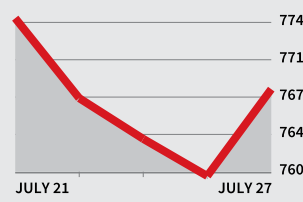


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76835.78 (+776.01)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23995.95	+228.50
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.64	+0.16
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.91	-0.65
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	143888.00	+683
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	224447.00	+1726

STRONG PERFORMANCE.

Tata Sons FY26 net profit grows 22%, AGM on Aug 18 to consider N Chandrasekaran's reappointment as Chairman **p9**



WELFARE WAIT.

Ayushman Bharat cover eludes gig workers even as 10.65 lakh join e-Shram portal **p12**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

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QUICKLY.

MISTRY'S OBJECTIONS
Charity Commissioner to hear Tata Trusts on Sept 8



Mumbai: The Maharashtra Charity Commissioner will hear Tata Trusts' response to former trustee Mehli Mistry's complaint on September 8. At Monday's hearing, counsel for the Sir Ratan Tata Trust and Sir Dorabji Tata Trust sought six weeks to file their response to Mistry's objections. **p2**

CUTTING UREA IMPORTS
Govt allows use of ammonia in farming

New Delhi: Amid strong demand and tight urea supplies, the government has permitted the use of anhydrous ammonia, which contains 82 per cent nitrogen, for agriculture. Urea, the country's most widely used fertilizer, contains 46 per cent nitrogen. However, India is still a long way away from building the infrastructure that is needed to transport, store and inject ammonia into farmers' fields. **p10**

MSRDC case: HDFC Bank board warns CEO, CFO, staff

BUSINESS OVERREACH. No *mala fide* action found; penalty of ₹1 lakh levied

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The board of HDFC Bank has decided to issue warning letters and impose a monetary penalty of ₹1 lakh each on Managing Director and CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan, the Chief Financial Officer, and the Group Head of Retail Assets in connection with the mobilisation of deposits from the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) in 2017 and 2021.

At its meeting on July 23, the board also resolved to issue warning letters to other employees involved in the matter.

The decision was based on the findings and recommendations of the Special Disciplinary Committee of Independent Directors.

According to a regulatory filing by the bank on Monday, the board concluded that the conduct of the employees involved amounted to "business overreach" rather than any *mala fide* action, personal enrichment or improper motive.



AUDIT ACTION. On March 12, HDFC Bank's Audit Committee ordered a vigilance probe into ₹45 crore paid to MSRDC as "differential interest" on deposits during FY24 and FY25

PASSING THE BUCK

Independent analyst Arun Kejriwal, however, criticised the board's response. "This shows the board has passed the buck without taking responsibility. If action has indeed been taken against five senior officials, the most senior person should have been held accountable through stricter disciplinary action. The board appears to have brushed aside the issue," he said.

Kejriwal argued that stronger punitive measures would have sent a clearer message about accountability and corporate gov-

ernance standards within the organisation.

Banking expert V Viswanathan said the bank's regulatory filing lacked sufficient detail, arguing that while there may have been no *mala fide* intent, the episode reflected a failure of corporate governance. He said routing interest payments through marketing expenses set a poor precedent for employees and stressed that the board should have commented on the governance lapses of senior executives. Describing the matter merely as "business overreach" was inadequate, he added.

The board action comes against the backdrop of the resignation in March of Chairman Atanu Chakraborty, expressing concerns over certain practices within the bank.

The matter gains significance as MD and CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan's second term ends in October 2026, with the board, now led by Chairman Rajiv Kumar, set to recommend the bank's leadership succession to the RBI.

CASE BACKGROUND

The Indian Express had reported that HDFC Bank's Audit Committee, on March 12, 2026, ordered a vigilance probe into ₹45 crore paid to MSRDC as "differential interest" on deposits during FY24 and FY25. It alleged that the amount was routed through the bank's marketing department and shown as contributions to a road-safety awareness campaign via four local vendors, instead of being credited directly as interest to MSRDC.

The matter is expected to remain under scrutiny as the board considers the bank's future leadership.

Threat actor may have 1 TB data of BoB accounts; bank opens forensic probe

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

A threat actor claims to possess around 1 TB of data linked to Bank of Baroda (BoB), per posts by cyber threat intelligence accounts and independent cybersecurity researchers. While the claim has not been independently verified, the bank said the incident stemmed from the compromise of an employee's email account, and that its core banking systems were not accessed.

The alleged breach surfaced on social media, where the threat actor claimed to have published sample files and download links.

The posts alleged that the dataset includes personal (e-KYC) and corporate banking records covering savings and current accounts, loans, net banking users, NRI and corporate banking services, customer support, and branch and ATM operations.

In a statement, BoB said containment measures were initiated immediately and its core banking systems remained secure. The bank has launched a forensic investigation.

Falling crude oil lifts equities, rupee and bonds

Our Bureau
Mumbai

A sharp fall in crude oil prices after the US and Iran paused military strikes lifted sentiment across India's financial markets on Monday, helping equities snap a five-day losing streak, strengthening the rupee and pushing bond yields lower.

Strong buying in the final hour lifted the BSE Sensex 776 points to 76,836, while the Nifty gained 228 points to close just shy of 24,000. Despite the rally, foreign institutional investors (FIIs) remained net sellers at ₹1,688 crore, while domestic institutional investors (DIIs) bought shares worth ₹2,329 crore, adding about ₹5.1 lakh crore to investors' wealth.

CRUDE SLIPS

Brent crude tumbled 4.1 per cent to around \$92.82. Lower oil prices are a major positive for India, the world's third-largest crude importer.

"The decline in crude prices provided near-term relief to equities, especially after markets had entered oversold territory," said Kranthi Bathini, Director-Equity Strategy at

Bulls gain control

	Today's close	% Change
Gold (995)	₹1,43,888	₹683 ↑
Crude	\$92.82	-4.1 ↓
Sensex	76,835.78	1.02 ↑
Nifty	23,995.95	0.96 ↑
Rupee	95.91	0.65 ↑

WealthMills Securities. However, he cautioned that the rally's sustainability would hinge on geopolitical developments and uninterrupted crude shipments through the Strait of Hormuz.

The positive sentiment spilled over to the currency market, with the rupee posting its biggest single-day gain in seven weeks.

Investor sentiment also drew support from RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra's interview with *businessline*, in which he said banks had mobilised nearly \$32 billion, largely through FCNR(B) deposits, while maintaining that the rupee was not overvalued and remained aligned with economic fundamentals.

The bond market rallied as well, with the benchmark 10-year government bond yield easing five basis points to 6.78 per cent from 6.83 per cent.

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank

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Scan QR to View Detailed Financial Results



Unaudited (Reviewed) Financial Results For The Quarter Ended 30th June 2026

Particulars	Quarter Ended 30 th June 2026	Quarter Ended 30 th June 2025	Change/Growth %
↑ TOTAL DEPOSITS	64,409	53,803	19.71
↑ TOTAL ADVANCES	57,306	45,120	27.01
↑ CASA	16,852	14,411	16.94
↑ OPERATING PROFIT	611	412	48.22
↑ NET PROFIT	412	305	34.97
↑ NET INTEREST INCOME	765	580	32.01
↓ GROSS NPA %	0.69	1.22	53 BPS
↓ NET NPA %	0.17	0.33	16 BPS
↑ NIM %	4.29	3.84	45 BPS
↑ ROA %	2.14	1.82	32 BPS
↑ ROE %	15.93	13.30	263 BPS
↑ CRAR %	32.33	31.55	78 BPS
↑ EPS (₹) (Not Annualised)	25.99	19.25	35.01

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended 30-06-2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter Ended 30-06-2025 (Unaudited)	Year Ended 31-03-2026 (Audited)
		₹ in crore		
1	Total Income from Operations (Net)	1,900.79	1,617.47	6,696.49
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period, (exceptional and/ or extraordinary items)	557.14	403.92	1,806.60
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax, (after exceptional and/ or extraordinary items)	557.14	403.92	1,806.60
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax, (after exceptional and/ or extraordinary items)	411.51	304.89	1,337.55
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (comprising Profit / Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)	NA	NA	NA
6	Paid-up Equity Share Capital	158.35	158.35	158.35
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserves)	10,403.67	9,169.92	9,951.81
8	Securities (Premium Account)	769.23	769.23	769.23
9	Net Worth	10,562.02	9,328.27	10,110.16
10	Paid-up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	-	-	-
11	Debt-Equity Ratio	0.05	-	0.02
12	Earnings Per Share (of ₹10/- each) (Not annualised) (For continuing and discontinued operations)	25.99 (a) Basic (b) Diluted	19.25 19.25	84.47 84.47
13	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-
14	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-

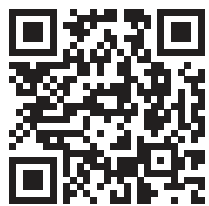
NOTE: 1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly/Yearly Financial Results filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/Yearly Financial Results is available on the website of the Stock Exchange(s) (www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com) and on the Bank's Website (www.tmb.bank.in). 2. Information relating to Total comprehensive income and other comprehensive income is not furnished as Ind-AS is not yet made applicable to banks. **Place:** Thoothukudi **Date:** 27.07.2026

On Behalf of
Board of Directors
SALEE S NAIR
Managing Director & CEO

Toll-free: 180 0425 0426 | www.tmb.bank.in

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QUICKLY.

Piramal concludes Biodeal investment



Mumbai: Piramal Alternatives has concluded its investment in Biodeal Pharmaceuticals, achieving an internal rate of return of over 20 per cent following the full redemption of its ₹110 crore investment. The investment was through Piramal Structured Credit Opportunities Fund, which invested ₹110 crore in Biodeal (2024) as part of its strategy to back high-growth healthcare and pharmaceutical businesses with strong fundamentals and scalable business models. The successful exit marks the culmination of a partnership during which Biodeal delivered operational and financial progress, strengthening its manufacturing capabilities, governance framework and operational discipline, and laying a strong foundation for its next phase of growth. OUR BUREAU

JK Paper Q1 net surges 63% on higher volumes

New Delhi: JK Paper Ltd on Monday reported a 63 per cent jump in consolidated net profit to ₹136.27 crore in the first quarter ended June 30 on the back of higher volumes and an improved product mix. The company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹83.75 crore in the corresponding quarter last fiscal, said JK Paper. Its consolidated revenue from operations in the first quarter was ₹1,998.67 crore against ₹1,771.78 crore in the year-ago period, it added. “While the paper and board market remained challenging, higher volumes and improved product mix led to better performance in the current quarter, compared to the corresponding period,” said JK Paper CMD Harsh Pati Singhania. PI

TMB profit up 35% on core business growth

Scorecard			
	Q1FY27	Q1FY26	Growth %
Net profit	412	305	35
Net interest income	765	580	32
Total deposits	64,409	53,803	20
Total advances	57,306	45,120	27
Gross NPA %	0.69	1.22	-53 bps
Net NPA %	0.17	0.33	-16 bps

Our Bureau

Chennai

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank (TMB) on Monday reported a 35 per cent year-on-year growth in net profit for the quarter ended June 2026 (Q1FY27) at ₹412 crore against ₹305 crore in the same quarter last year. Net interest income (NII) increased to ₹765 crore from ₹580 crore, a growth of 32 per cent y-o-y. Net interest margin (NIM) improved to 4.3 per cent from 3.8 per cent in the year-ago period. At ₹64,409 crore, deposits grew 19.7 per cent y-o-y in Q1FY27 and at ₹57,306 crore advances saw a robust 27 per cent y-o-y growth. Total business stood at ₹1,21,715 crore, a rise of 23 per cent. Advances growth came largely from a surge in retail loans (36 per cent y-o-y) and also a healthy growth in agri loans (30 per cent y-o-y). At ₹23,399 crore, agri loans now make up almost 40 per cent of total advances of the bank.

RISE IN CASA

The bank's CASA has increased to ₹16,852 crore, with a growth rate of 17 per cent on a y-o-y basis. NIM was slightly down 46 basis points from June 2025 to 4.29 per cent in the year-ago period.

Salee S Nair, MD and CEO, Tamilnad Mercantile Bank, said the first quarter of FY27 had brought a positive start, and the growth delivered during the quarter is broad-based, supported by healthy business momentum, improved operating perform-

Canara Bank profit up 2% to ₹4,856 cr on credit growth

AIMING BIG. Management has guided for 11-12% growth in global advances in FY27

Our Bureau

Bengaluru

State-owned Canara Bank on Monday reported a 2.19 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) increase in standalone net profit at ₹4,856 crore for the first quarter ended June 30, 2026, supported by double-digit credit growth and steady improvement in asset quality.

Net interest income (NII) grew 13.39 per cent y-o-y to ₹10,215 crore, while total income rose 4.26 per cent to ₹39,684 crore.

The lender's global business expanded 14.37 per cent y-o-y to ₹29,05,066 crore in the quarter. Global advances jumped 17.97 per cent to ₹12,93,381 crore, driven primarily by retail, agriculture, and MSME (RAM) credit, which surged 21.2 per cent.

Within retail, housing loans grew 17.85 per cent to ₹1,29,036 crore, and vehicle loans rose 26.34 per cent. Total global deposits in-

Scorecard

	Q1FY26	Q1FY27	% change
Net profit (₹ crore)	4,752	4,856	2.19
NIM (quarterly) (%)	2.55	2.52	-
Net interest income (₹ crore)	9,009	10,215	13.39
Slippage (₹ crore)	0.20	0.15	-



creased 11.63 per cent y-o-y to ₹16,11,685 crore, with domestic deposits at ₹14,73,447 crore.

Fee income for the quarter improved 5.35 per cent to ₹2,342 crore, while operating profit rose marginally by 0.96 per cent to ₹8,636 crore.

ASSET QUALITY

On a sequential basis, asset quality indicators strengthened further across

key metrics. Gross non-performing assets (GNPA) improved by 27 basis points quarter-on-quarter to 1.57 per cent as of June 2026, down from 1.84 per cent in March 2026 and 2.69 per cent in June 2025.

Net NPA fell by 7 basis points sequentially to 0.36 per cent from 0.43 per cent in the previous quarter and 0.63 per cent a year ago. The provision coverage ra-

tio (PCR) improved to 94.76 per cent from 94.21 per cent as of March 2026.

CAPITAL POSITION

The bank maintained a comfortable capital position with its capital to risk-weighted assets ratio (CRAR) standing at 17.17 per cent, of which common equity tier-1 (CET-1) was 12.91 per cent.

Slippages remained low at 0.6 per cent, while credit costs improved by 23 basis points year-on-year to 0.49 per cent.

The bank is also projecting the FCNR (B) and overseas borrowing window for the fiscal year to exceed \$2.3-2.5 billion, said Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer Brajesh Kumar Singh.

The management has guided for 11-12 per cent growth in global advances and 9-10 per cent growth in global deposits for FY27, while expressing confidence that the bank could exceed its loan growth target based on recent momentum.

₹ outperforms EM peers since March as RBI measures cushion war shocks

Sourashis Banerjee

Chennai

The rupee strengthened against the dollar by approximately 61 paise on July 27, compared to its previous closing level to settle at 95.92, following the halt in hostilities between the US and Iran sending crude oil prices lower. While the rupee has lost 5.1 per cent against the dollar between February 27 and July 27 when the West Asia conflict kept crude oil prices volatile, it still outper-

DATA FOCUS.

formed several emerging market (EM) peers. Indonesia's rupiah declined 6.9 per cent, the Philippine peso 6.5 per cent and Thailand's baht 7.4 per cent against the rupee over the same period.

This marks a sharp turnaround from the 12 months before the war when the rupee was among the weakest-performing major emerging market currencies. The contrast suggests that the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) policy interventions helped the rupee weather oil price shocks better than many of its peers.

RBI STEPS IN

The West Asia conflict, which began on February 27, triggered a broad sell-off in the currencies of energy-importing economies as fears of supply disruptions and elevated crude oil prices weighed on external balances. India was no exception, with the rupee weakening steadily in the initial months of the conflict.

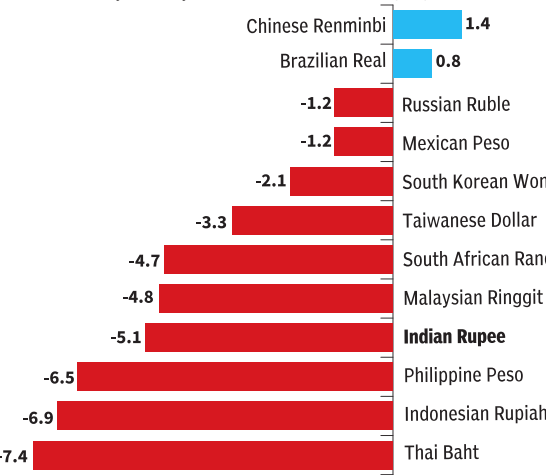
To stabilise foreign currency inflows and improve dollar liquidity, the RBI announced three measures between June 5 and June 8 — easing norms for External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs), enhancing the attractiveness of Foreign Currency Non-Resident (bank) [FCNR (B)] deposits and liberalising investment limits for foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) in specified

Rupee vs the rest

Currency puts up a better show since Iran war

period: February 27- July 27, 2026

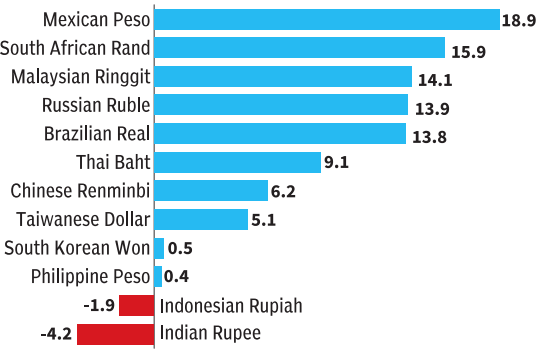
Change against the \$ (in %)



The year before the war was nightmarish for the rupee

period: February 27, 2025- February 27, 2026

Change against the \$ (in %)



Source: Bloomberg

debt instruments. The measures were followed by a sharp reversal in overseas portfolio flows. FPIs, which recorded a net outflow of ₹29,400 crore in May, turned net buyers with inflows of ₹4,600 crore in June and ₹36,400 crore in July up to July 27. Due to the FCNR(B) leeway, banks mobilised inflows of around \$32 billion till date, mostly through the FCNR(B) channel.

PRE-WAR PERIOD

The rupee's relative resilience during the conflict stands in stark contrast to its performance in the year leading up to the war.

Between February 27, 2025, and February 27, 2026, the rupee depreciated 4.2 per cent against the US dollar, making it one of the weakest-

performing currencies in the comparison. Only the Indonesian rupiah (-1.9 per cent) and Japanese yen (-4.0 per cent) fared similarly poorly, while currencies such as the Mexican peso, South African rand, Malaysian ringgit, Brazilian real and Russian rouble appreciated by 13-19 per cent.

That period was marked by uncertainty surrounding US tariff policies and heavy foreign portfolio outflows from Indian markets, which put sustained pressure on the rupee. The improved relative performance since March suggests that policy support and stabilising capital flows have helped narrow the gap between the rupee and its emerging market peers despite a challenging external environment.

Coal India net rises marginally to ₹8,850 crore, total income up 8%

Our Bureau

Kolkata

State-run coal behemoth Coal India on Monday reported a marginal 0.7 per cent year-on-year increase in consolidated net profit at ₹8,849.81 crore for the first quarter this fiscal, with total income and total expenditure rising around 8 per cent and 12 per cent y-o-y.

The coal miner had reported a net profit of ₹8,787.84 crore in the first quarter of FY26.

Backed by a 7.77 per cent y-o-y rise in revenue from operations, the company's total income in Q1FY27 witnessed an increase of 8.44 per cent y-o-y at ₹48,295.27 crore compared with ₹44,535.06 crore.

CIL's revenue from operations in the period under review grew to ₹46,254.80 crore against ₹42,919.20 crore in the year-ago period, according to a stock exchange filing.

Scorecard

	Q1FY27	Q1FY26	Y-o-Y change (%)
Net Profit	8,849.81	8,787.84	0.7
Revenue from operations	46,254.8	42,919.20	7.77
Total Income	48,295.27	44,535.06	8.44
Total Expenses	36816.23	32903.19	11.89

(All figures are in ₹ cr, except percentages) Source: Company

Overall average realisation of coal in the first quarter stood at ₹2,276.62 per tonne, registering a 3 per cent y-o-y growth.

In the first quarter, for the fuel supply agreement (FSA), there was a 1.38 per cent y-o-y increase in quantity at 168.07 million tonnes and also a 1.12 per cent rise in per tonne realisation at ₹2,099.41.

E-AUCTION

For the e-auction in Q1FY27, there was a 24.8 per cent increase in quantity at 26.52 million tonnes, and per tonne realisation increased by 5.77 per cent to ₹3,085.44.

Our Bureau

Chennai

Wheels India Ltd reported a 30 per cent rise in consolidated net profit at ₹38 crore for the first quarter ended June 30, 2026, against ₹30 crore in the same quarter last year. Consolidated revenue increased 18 per cent to ₹1,491 crore (₹1,266 crore).

On a standalone basis, Wheels India's revenue for Q1FY27 went up 16.8 per cent to ₹1,386 crore, compared to ₹1,187 crore in the same period last year. Net profit grew 42 per cent to ₹37 crore.

“The company's sales grew along with the domestic market for cars, trucks and agriculture tractors that continued their momentum post GST 2.0 reforms. We saw growth in the export of construction equipment wheels. There were strong inflationary pressures on material costs due to the West Asia crisis,” said Srivats Ram, CMD.



MORE POWER. Honda ZR-V's value lies in restoring the premium flagship position left vacant by CR-V and Accord

Vice-President, Marketing & Sales, Honda Cars India.

While Honda is upbeat on the ZR-V, the bigger challenge lies elsewhere. Industry data show that Amaze accounted for nearly 59 per cent of Honda's domestic wholesale volumes in Q1FY27, highlighting the

company's continued dependence on its compact sedan even as utility vehicles accounted for about 68 per cent of passenger vehicle wholesales during the quarter.

With Crisil expecting SUV share to rise to around 69 per cent in FY27, Honda's revival

NTPC posts ₹27,546 cr record profit in FY26

Our Bureau

Mumbai

NTPC Ltd, India's largest power generator, reported a record group profit of ₹27,546 crore in FY26, a rise of roughly 15 per cent over the previous year's ₹23,953 crore, according to its investor presentation at the 22nd Annual Analysts and Institutional Investors' Meet held on July 27.

The state-owned utility also recorded its highest-ever group capital expenditure of ₹55,986 crore in FY26, signalling aggressive capacity expansion plans. Consolidated EBITDA grew to ₹60,564 crore, maintaining a four-year CAGR of 8.54 per cent. Group net worth stood at ₹2,03,024 crore as of March 31, 2026.

NTPC added 9.6 GW of capacity in FY26, taking its total operational capacity to 90.9 GW across the group. A further 35.7 GW is under construction. The com-

pany's renewable energy capacity reached 12 GW operationally, with a visible pipeline of approximately 30 GW and target of 60 GW by FY32 and 136 GW by FY37.

CORPORATE PLAN 2037

Under its Corporate Plan 2037, NTPC aims for a total portfolio of 250 GW.

On the operational front, NTPC coal stations achieved a plant load factor of 72.04 per cent in FY26, maintaining a clear lead over the all-India average of 65.59 per cent.

Coal production from captive mines reached 48.66 million tonnes in FY26.

CASH DIVIDEND

The company declared the highest-ever cash dividend in FY26, with total dividend outflow of ₹14,435 crore at a payout ratio of 38 per cent.

Trade receivables improved sharply to 15 days from 31 days in the previous year, reflecting stronger payment realisation.

businessline.

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The Unique Investors count for Mutual Fund industry is 6,19,39,221 (Source: AMFI), and that for Nippon India Mutual Fund is 2,41,27,924. Market Share: 38.95%. The folio count for Nippon India Mutual Fund is: 4,01,67,296. Data as on: 30th June 2026. *Monday to Saturday 8 AM to 9 PM. Call charges applicable.

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Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

A nuke deal with a rider

The US thrusts Abraham Accords on Saudi Arabia

Sridhar Krishnaswami

Less than a day after the announcement of a US-Saudi Arabia civilian nuclear agreement, President Donald Trump dropped a bombshell making many wonder if there is an accord at all. “The Civil Nuclear Deal (There will be no enrichment of material!) which pertains only to non-military use... will be approved, but is totally subject to Saudi Arabia joining the very respected and successful Abraham Accords,” the President said on Truth Social. In the absence of any available text, it is unclear if this conditionality is a part of the agreement.

It is no secret that Washington and Riyadh have been discussing the civilian nuclear deal for quite sometime; but Saudi Arabia has been one of the staunch supporters of the Palestinian cause, pushing for a meaningful two-state solution and holding off on being a part of the Abraham Accords that would have opened the door for the formal recognition of the Jewish state.

And in the last two years or more what complicated the nuclear deal was the October 7, 2023, terrorist attack on Israel and the savage response of Tel Aviv in the Gaza in the name of wiping out the Hamas.

The scale of death and destruction in the name of retaliation did not sit well in the Arab world, to put it mildly.

BACKLASH BREWING

Even before Trump came up with his Abraham Accords conditionality, the backlash seemed to be brewing on Capitol Hill and elsewhere especially in the non-proliferation community. The civilian nuclear deal, according to many experts, lacked essentially three things that have been held up as the “Gold Standard” of civilian nuclear energy agreements: a commitment from Riyadh not to use American built plants to enrich nuclear fuel; no reprocessing for weapons; and plants subject to international inspections.

“A bad US nuclear deal with Saudi Arabia is coming for congressional review — inexplicably, carried over from the Biden administration,” Andrea Stricker of the Foundation for Defense of Democracies has said. “Congress should block it. If it does not, one hopes the policy will be reversed by a subsequent administration before too much



DEAL FALLOUT. The nuke issue with Iran will get complicated REUTERS

damage is done in terms of watering down safeguards, setting negative precedents for other states, and failing to contain the spread of enrichment and reprocessing — which we just put back in the box in Iran via force”. From what is available from media reports, the nuclear deal is open to inspections only by the US and Saudi Arabia with no involvement of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA).

In the immediate context, the US-Saudi Arabia nuclear deal — even without the conditionality of the Abraham Accords — would create additional headaches on the Iran front if and when negotiations resume.

For the Trump administration to come down hard on Iran for its nuclear programme and still give Saudi Arabia a wide berth with no involvement of the IAEA and its Protocols makes discussions on the nuclear issue with Tehran more complicated. It also strengthens the hand of hawks and hardliners in Tehran who have always pointed to the dual standards of Washington.

What has been consistently pointed out is that for all the noise made by the West on the nuclear programmes of Iran and North Korea, there is hardly a murmur about Israel which is generally seen as an undeclared nuclear power.

The American nuclear industry must be elated seeing the billions and perhaps even trillions coming its way through an exclusive accord designed to keep China and Russia out.

But those in the business of non-proliferation worry about Beijing and Moscow going about cutting their own exclusives and without the involvement of the IAEA and its Protocols. Add to this the possibility of mischievous and known proliferationists lending their weight — and it is truly a nightmarish scenario.

The writer is a senior journalist who has reported from Washington DC on North America and United Nations



AJAY SAHAI

The US’ decision to impose an additional 10 per cent Section 301 tariff on most imports from India has understandably created concern among exporters. Yet, while the measure is undoubtedly a setback, it should not be viewed as a blow to India’s export prospects. Compared with several competing countries, India could even emerge with fresh opportunities in a number of sectors.

It must be noted that this is not a country-specific penalty against India, nor is it a finding that Indian products are manufactured using forced labour. The tariff forms part of a broader US trade action under Section 301 following its assessment of how trading partners prohibit and prevent the import of goods produced through forced labour. India has been placed in the lower 10 per cent tariff category after taking policy measures to strengthen its legal framework in this area, while several competing countries have been subjected to a higher tariff of 12.5 per cent.

COMMERCIAL REALITY

For exporters, however, the commercial reality is straightforward. The new levy generally comes in addition to the existing US customs duty. Thus, if an Indian product currently attracts a normal US import duty of 5 per cent, the new Section 301 tariff could raise the total duty incidence to around 15 per cent. Naturally, this increases the landed cost of Indian products in the US market and may make price negotiations more difficult. Since customs duties are paid by the US importer, buyers are likely to seek price reductions, renegotiate contracts, or ask exporters to share part of the additional burden. Industries operating on narrow profit margins will feel this impact much more sharply than sectors supplying specialised or high-value products.

At the same time, looking only at the additional 10 per cent tariff can create a misleading impression. India competes with dozens of countries in the US market, and the real question is whether those competitors face lower, similar or higher duties.

Many of India’s principal competitors, including Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, Malaysia, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Mexico, Canada, the UK and Jordan, have also been subjected to the same 10 per cent tariff. This means that in sectors such as textiles, garments, leather products and several labour-intensive industries, Indian exporters do not become less competitive merely because of the new tariff. Buyers comparing Indian products with those from Bangladesh or Sri Lanka, for example, will find both facing similar tariff treatment.

Interestingly, India may actually gain

US’ new tariff needn’t rattle exporters

NOT A HARD BLOW. Section 301 tariff on many of India’s principal competitors is either higher or similar. Our competitiveness hence may not get affected



BLOOMBERG

a modest competitive advantage over several important exporting nations. Vietnam, Thailand, China, Türkiye, Singapore, Brazil, South Africa, Australia, New Zealand, Saudi Arabia and the UAE have all been placed in the higher 12.5 per cent tariff category. Although the difference is only 2.5 per cent, it could become significant in highly price-sensitive industries. US buyers looking to diversify away from suppliers facing higher tariffs may increasingly consider Indian manufacturers, provided they can offer competitive prices, consistent quality, reliable delivery schedules and adequate production capacity.

The picture becomes less favourable when India competes with developed economies. The European Union and Taiwan have been granted a much more favourable capped-duty arrangement under which the combined customs duty generally does not exceed 10 per cent. Japan, South Korea and Switzerland also enjoy a similar arrangement with a cap of 12.5 per cent. Consequently, Indian exporters may find themselves at a slight disadvantage in machinery, electrical equipment, engineering goods, speciality chemicals, medical devices and other technology-intensive sectors

There is no single answer to the impact of the tariff. Every product has to be examined individually after comparing the tariff treatment applicable to competing supplier countries

where European and East Asian suppliers are India’s principal competitors. This underlines an important lesson: there is no single answer to the impact of the tariff. Every product has to be examined individually after comparing the tariff treatment applicable to competing supplier countries.

The impact will also vary considerably across sectors. The gems and jewellery industry, where competition is intense and margins are often low, may face considerable pressure. Textiles and garments, on the other hand, may witness a more balanced impact because most competing South Asian suppliers face the same tariff. However, the proposed US tariff-rate quota for countries importing American cotton and textile inputs could potentially provide Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia and Malaysia with an additional advantage if implemented favourably.

Pharmaceuticals appear comparatively insulated because several pharmaceutical products and ingredients fall within the exemption framework, although exporters should verify product-specific classifications rather than assuming blanket exemptions. Similarly, certain agricultural commodities, fertilizer inputs, seeds and essential products have also been kept outside the scope of the new tariff.

GREATER SCRUTINY

Another consequence of the new measure is likely to be greater scrutiny of supply chains by American buyers. Exporters should therefore strengthen documentation relating to labour practices, wages, employment

conditions, supplier declarations, raw material sourcing, social audits and traceability. Businesses with transparent supply chains and strong environmental, social and governance practices are likely to inspire greater confidence among overseas buyers.

The immediate response of exporters should be to obtain confirmation of the precise US tariff classification applicable to their products and verify whether any exclusions are available. They should calculate the total landed duty, taking into account the normal customs duty, the Section 301 tariff, any applicable Section 232 duties and other trade remedies wherever relevant.

Existing export contracts should also be reviewed carefully to determine who bears the additional duty burden and whether price revisions are permissible under the contract. Instead of immediately offering a 10 per cent reduction in prices, exporters would be better advised to negotiate balanced commercial solutions such as partial cost sharing, larger order commitments, improved logistics, revised specifications or longer-term supply arrangements. Most importantly, exporters should assess every product on a tariff-line-by-tariff-line basis and compare their position with the principal competing countries rather than drawing broad conclusions.

The new US tariff undoubtedly increases the landed cost of Indian products. Businesses operating on margins of only 3-8 per cent will find it difficult to absorb an additional 10 per cent tariff without affecting profitability. Nevertheless, the overall picture is more balanced than it appears at first glance.

The writer is Director General and CEO, FIEO

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

July 28, 2006

MFs’ overseas investment norms eased

The RBI has raised the ceiling for overseas investment by mutual funds from \$1 billion to \$2 billion. Select mutual funds would also be allowed to invest in exchange traded funds cumulatively for \$1 billion, permitted by SEBI, an RBI notification said.

Rumours create panic in commodity markets

Strong rumours of the Centre bringing back storage and licensing controls under the Essential Commodities Act (ECA) have created a panic-like situation in the agro-commodities markets. Prices of most commodities, particularly pulses, fell on Thursday on the National Commodity and Derivatives Exchange.

Private sector offers job reservation

A section of the industry has voluntarily offered to provide reservation in private jobs to the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. At a meeting of the representatives of CII and Assocham, and the Tata Sons Director, JJ Irani, with the Prime Minister, Dr Manmohan Singh, it was assured that members of the two chambers will provide reservation through a mandatory code of conduct to the economically and socially weaker SCs and STs.

China’s industrial profit sees weakest growth

Bloomberg News

China’s industry saw profit gains slow for a second month, adding to evidence of an uneven recovery for companies across parts of the world’s second-biggest economy.

Industrial profits rose 15.1 per cent last month from a year earlier, the weakest increase this year and down from 21.1 per cent in May, according to data published by the National Bureau of Statistics on Monday.

For the first half of the year, companies grew earnings by 18.7 per cent, compared with a Bloomberg Economics forecast of 19.2 per cent.

China ended its record deflationary run last quarter even as price increases

remain largely confined to oil and sectors linked to artificial intelligence. Though the cost of goods at the factory gate surged in June at the fastest in almost four years, producer prices had their first drop since July 2025 on a month-on-month basis, in a sign inflationary momentum has waned.

DEMAND FOR TECH GOODS

The global build-out of AI infrastructure has fuelled demand for China’s advanced manufactured goods, while disruptions to energy markets caused by the conflict in the Middle East have lifted commodity costs.

But slumping domestic investment and sluggish household spending could be more of a hurdle for profitability in the months ahead, especially in the



IN DEMAND. Advanced goods BLOOMBERG

absence of stronger stimulus to boost demand.

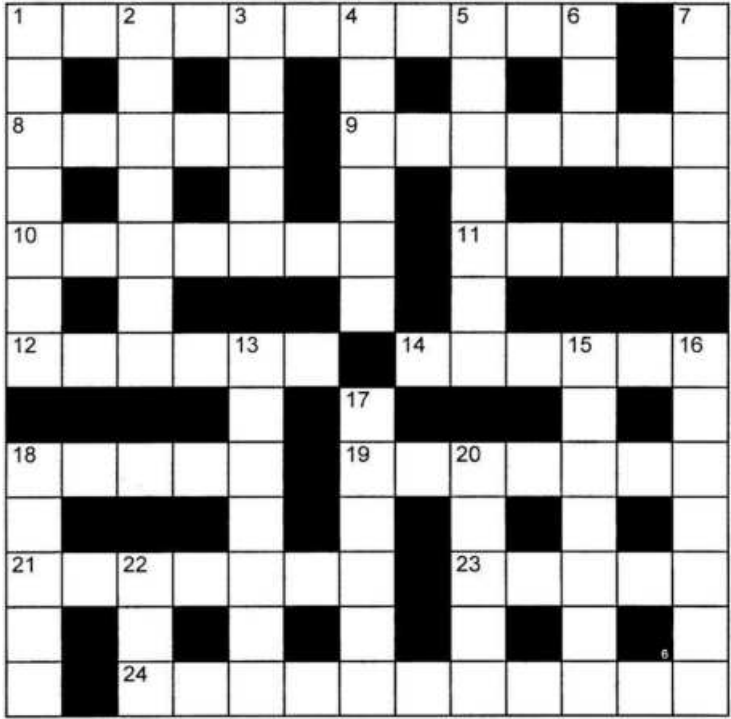
While industrial profits rose “relatively rapidly” in the first half, “the external environment remains complex and uncertain, international commodity prices continue to fluctuate unpredictably, and industrial

enterprises still face challenges including weak market demand and tight cash flow,” Yu Weining, an NBS analyst, said in a statement published alongside the data release.

Looking ahead, the government will continue to “cultivate and strengthen” emerging and future industries, while “upgrading and transforming” traditional sectors, to enable a smooth transition between the old and new growth drivers, Yu said.

The yield on the government’s 10-year debt was steady at 1.72 per cent after the data publication. With traders expecting looser monetary policy ahead, China’s 30-year bond futures rose as much as 0.2 per cent to the highest since November, extending their gains from last week.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2702



EASY

ACROSS

- You too? We’re all in the same position! (4,3,4)
- Stone craftsman (5)
- Man of great power and wealth (7)
- Illegal (7)
- Having weapons (5)
- _____ loci : spirit of the place (6)
- Church caretaker (6)
- Order of Greek architecture (5)
- A radioactive element (7)
- Not washed (7)
- In the style of (5)
- Stage act, appearance (11)

DOWN

- Leaping (7)
- Extract used in treatment of diabetes (7)
- A pick-me-up (5)
- Hostility (6)
- Travellers’ cases (7)
- Snake (3)
- ‘Money’ (5)
- Not plain (7)
- Shine wetly (7)
- Gnawing pain of conscience (7)
- Government-appointed consultant body (6)
- Be uncertain (5)
- Warning of danger (5)
- Chalice (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Pay your first subscription – it’s the same for everybody! (4,3,4)
- Mother and her boy, a craftsman (5)
- Man of wealth and power who can get a man in trouble (7)
- It isn’t legal till one goes round the Channel Islands (7)
- Has weapons to dream about (5)
- It may be an evil spirit, gin – use it, anyhow (6)
- Office of caretaker in church will border on rector initially (6)
- Order one to be covered in a sort of cord (5)
- Radioactive metal could ruin human insides (7)
- Putting an uncle out, which is not kosher (7)
- Is following in search of raft drifting around the East (5)
- A recital from France, or MEP who makes it (11)

DOWN

- This Jack, taking the gun, is off too soon (7)
- It regulates our glucose and gives us nil in compound form (7)
- This may be the key to a gin mixer (5)
- Ill-will shown when I’m put up in Tyne like this (6)
- Haul the gauntlet along with the cases (7)
- This may snake over a woman’s shoulders (3)
- The staff of life is not alone to be lived by (5)
- Pawnbroker has a right to it, but it’s not obvious (7)
- Single tabletop that could shine when it’s wet (7)
- The compunction with which some err maybe (7)
- Board giving part question, part answer, is to disappear (6)
- Be in two minds but do it anyhow (5)
- Consternation that exists among several armament makers (5)
- Award one will hollow one’s hands for (3)

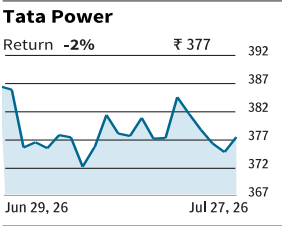
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2701

ACROSS 1. Brunt 4. Felucca 8. Overindulgent 10. Solve 11. Need 12. High 16. Parka 17. Philanthropic 19. Rankles 20. Panel

DOWN 1. Blotting paper 2. Use 3. Thirst 4. Fiddle 5. Lulled 6. Credulity 7. Astrophysical 9. Precision 13. Sprawl 14. Gratis 15. Satrap 18. Pin

QUICKLY.

Tata Power board okays raising ₹4,500 cr via NCDs



New Delhi: The Tata Power board on Monday approved raising of up to ₹4,500 crore through non-convertible debentures or other debt securities in one or more currencies on a private placement basis. The funds raised will be utilised for refinancing of existing loans. According to an exchange filing, the Board of Directors at its meeting held on Monday approved issuance in one or more series/tranches, non-cumulative, redeemable, taxable, listed, and rated securities in the form of NCDs/bonds/other debt securities up to an aggregate amount not exceeding ₹4,500 crore (debt securities) or its equivalent in one or more currencies on a private placement basis. **■**

Master Chains N Jewels files IPO papers with SEBI

New Delhi: Organised gold jewellery manufacturer and wholesale distributor Master Chains N Jewels Ltd has filed preliminary papers with SEBI to raise funds through an initial public offering (IPO). The proposed IPO comprises a fresh issue of shares worth up to ₹400 crore and an Offer for Sale (OFS) of up to 59.06 lakh shares by promoter Taruna Madan Kothari, according to the draft red herring prospectus filed on Saturday. The proceeds from the fresh issue will be utilised towards funding the company's working capital requirements and for general corporate purposes. **■**

Juniper Green fixes IPO price band at ₹214-225, issue opens on July 30

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Juniper Green Energy plans to raise ₹1,800 crore through an IPO. The issue, priced at ₹214-225 a share will open for subscription on July 30. The IPO comprises entirely a fresh issue of equity shares, with no offer-for-sale component. Investors can bid for a minimum of 66 equity shares.

USE OF FUNDS

The company plans to use ₹683 crore from the net proceeds to repay certain borrowings. It will also invest ₹729 crore in its subsidiaries — Juniper Green Gamma One, Juniper Green Kite and Juniper Green Power Five — to enable them to repay their outstanding debt. The remaining proceeds will be used for general corporate purposes. Its consolidated outstanding fund-based borrowings stood at

MV Electrosystems IPO opens on July 30 in ₹400-425 band

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

MV Electrosystems on Monday fixed a price band of ₹400 to ₹425 per share for its ₹290-crore upcoming initial public offering (IPO). At the upper end of the price band, the company's market valuation is estimated at ₹1,160 crore post-listing. The company's public offering, which is entirely a fresh issue of shares with no offer for sale (OFS) component, will be open for subscription on July 30 and close on August 3, according to its statement. Proceeds from the fresh issue will support long-term working capital requirements, fund investment in research, design and development activities for new power electronic equipment, and cover general corporate purposes.

Jefferies raises IT sector to 'neutral' from 'underweight'

KEY TRIGGERS. Brokerage sees value after sharp fall in share prices, pause in AI trade

Our Bureau
Bangaluru

India's IT services sector has fallen 25 per cent year-to-date, with the top four IT majors — TCS, Infosys, HCLTech and Wipro — down around 35-50 per cent from their past two-year peaks. The sharp decline and a pause in the AI trade have prompted Jefferies to tactically close its longstanding 'Underweight' stance on IT services and raise the sector to 'Neutral'. The brokerage said IT services stocks had borne the brunt of concerns around artificial intelligence. However, as the AI trade pauses, Jefferies sees scope for tactical upside in the sector, particularly after the large decline in stock prices.

The top four IT majors are currently trading at 13-17 times price-to-earnings multiples, while revenue growth for IT stocks is expected to remain in the low-to-mid single digits over FY26-28E. Jefferies said the negative stock reaction to negative sector news has been much



softer, indicating a tactical bottom.

'FPIS TURN BULLISH' According to Jefferies, its interaction with more than 50 FPI investors suggested a positive change in sentiment towards India as the AI trade comes into question. It also noted that FPI flows have turned positive, while economic and corporate data points have surprised positively. As part of its tactical move, Jefferies added Infosys and raised its weight in Coforge in its model portfolio, taking its IT sector stance to neutral. The brokerage funded the move through weight trims in power, real estate and hospitals, while continuing to maintain large overweight positions in these sectors.

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Zepto in talks with anchor investors ahead of IPO

Jyoti Banthia
Bangaluru

Quick commerce firm Zepto has begun discussions with prospective anchor investors for its upcoming initial public offering (IPO), targeting a post-money valuation of around \$3 billion (about ₹29,100 crore), according to people familiar with the matter. The company, which competes with Blinkit and Swiggy Instamart, is expected to price its anchor book at a pre-money valuation of about ₹24,000 crore (\$2.5 billion), with a proposed fresh issue of ₹5,000 crore and a small offer for sale (OFS) component.



The indicative price works out to roughly ₹18.76 a share, according to the deal terms being discussed with investors. The move marks a sharp reset in Zepto's valuation expectations from its last private funding round. The company was valued at \$7 billion when it raised \$450 million from investors, including US Calpers, in October 2025.

Zepto had filed its UDRHP last month, which had proposed a fresh issue of up to ₹8,010 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of up to 113.47 million shares by existing investors. The UDRHP had listed Nexus Ventures, Contrary, Razor Ventures and entities linked to Kaiser Permanente among the selling shareholders.

VALUATION RESET

The revised valuation reflects the more measured pricing environment in the public markets, where investors are increasingly rewarding companies with stronger visibility on profitability and sustainable growth over aggressive private market multiples.

Zepto recently received the Securities and Exchange Board of India's approval for its IPO in April and has since been working towards its market debut. The company operates in India's intensely competitive quick commerce market, where it competes against Blinkit, backed by Eternal, and Swiggy Instamart, backed by Swiggy.

The sector continues to see rapid growth, but listed players have remained under pressure to balance expansion with profitability, influencing investor expectations for new-age technology listings. An email sent to Zepto seeking comment did not elicit a response.

Tata Consumer Q1 gets thumbs up from analysts

Our Bureau
Bangaluru

Shares of Tata Consumer Products rose 3.2 per cent on Monday, after the company posted 29 per cent year-on-year increase in consolidated net profit at ₹427 crore for the June quarter. The stock ended 1.78 per cent higher at ₹1,107.40 on the NSE, hit a high of ₹1,123.40 during the day. HSBC maintained its 'Buy' rating and raised the target price to ₹1,390 from ₹1,380. It said Q1FY27 delivered strong top-line growth despite a sequential margin miss in the India business due to cost inflation. HSBC said that margin guidance has been maintained and reduced its FY27-FY29 earnings estimates by 2-3 per cent to reflect the first-quarter margin miss.

Nomura, too, while retaining its 'Buy' rating, raised the target price to ₹1,475 from ₹1,450. It said growth businesses continue to outshine and are changing the company's business mix. The brokerage described the June-quarter performance as broadly in line with consensus estimates. Morgan Stanley maintained its 'Overweight' rating with a target price of ₹1,351. It sees near-term margin improvement through pricing, while US business margin recovery and India cost savings could support the company's medium-term EBITDA margin.

Citi maintained its 'Buy' rating but cut the target price to ₹1,400 from ₹1,450. It said strong growth momentum continues and highlighted incremental pricing, strong execution in emerging channels, continued innovation and the scaling-up of growth businesses as key positives.

IPOs of Indo-MIM, Xtranet, Lohia witness strong response

IPOs: Who bids					
	QIBs	Non-institutions	Retail	Employee	Total
Indo-MIM	204.34	50.63	6.67	9.44	72.34
Lohia Corp	9.11	6.82	2.77	1.39	7.25
Xtranet Technologies	7.13	26.65	8.98		12.24

Source: Exchange

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The three initial public offerings — Indo-MIM, Xtranet and Lohia Corp — that closed on Monday saw heavy subscription, especially the former attracting all category of investors. The Indo-MIM Ltd IPO closed with overall subscription of 72.34 times. The qualified institutional buyer category drove the surge, subscribing a massive 204.34 times its allotted portion. Domestic financial institutions, including banks, financial institutions and insurance companies, were the most aggressive within the QIB segment, bidding for 143.96 crore shares while foreign institutional investors followed with bids for 105.76 crore shares.

The non-institutional investor category closed at 50.63 times overall and retail investors 6.67 times. Employee reservation closed at 9.44 times. The public issue came out with a price band of ₹461-485 per share. The IPO comprised a fresh issue of ₹500 crore and an offer-for-sale of approximately ₹3,312 crore.

LOHIA CORP The Lohia Corp Ltd IPO closed was subscribed 7.25 times. The QIB category was the standout performer, subscribed 9.11 times, closely followed by NII at 6.82

times and retail investors 2.77 times.

The employee reservation portion was subscribed 1.39 times. The IPO, priced at ₹404-425 per share, is entirely an Offer for Sale of 2.59 crore shares. Lohia Corp, a global manufacturer of woven raffia machinery with a 40.7 per cent domestic market share, reported revenue of ₹1,717 crore in FY26 with EBITDA margins of 18.6 per cent.

XTRANET TECH

Xtranet Technologies Ltd's ₹170-crore IPO closed with overall subscription of 12.24 times.

The Non-Institutional Investor (NII) category was the standout, subscribed 26.65 times with both the large NII bucket (bids above ₹10 lakh) and the smaller bucket (₹2-10 lakh) each clocking approximately 26.7 and 26.5 times respectively. Xtranet Technologies Limited, an integrated IT solutions provider, launched its IPO at a price band of ₹120 to ₹127.

Retail investors subscribed 8.98 times and QIB category 7.13 times. The Bhopal-based integrated IT solutions provider, incorporated in 2002, had priced its fresh issue at ₹120-127 per share. Net proceeds are earmarked primarily for working capital requirements (₹102 crore), debt repayment (₹20.2 crore), and capital expenditure (₹8.5 crore).

BROKER'S CALL.

IDBI Capital

DCB BANK (BUY)

Target: ₹216
CMP: ₹190.20
DCB Bank reported a strong Q1-FY27, delivering its highest-ever quarterly profit, driven by lower funding costs, improving operating efficiency and stable asset quality. Management reiterated its focus on consistent, predictable and sustainable growth, led by stronger liabilities, higher productivity and disciplined capital allocation. Advances grew 17.1 per cent y-o-y to ₹59,951 crore, driven by mortgages, gold loans and Agri and Inclusive Banking, while deposits increased 20.1 per cent y-o-y to ₹74,482 crore. NIM expanded 15 bps y-o-y to 3.35 per cent and core fee income grew 31 per cent y-o-y to ₹175 crore. Asset quality improved with GNPA/NNPA at 2.43/0.84 per cent, PCR at 79.8 per cent and credit cost at 26 bps. The Management expects NIM to increase from Q2 onwards as higher-yield mortgages and agri products take a larger share of sourcing, with further cost-of-deposit reduction — realistically — 7-8 bps per quarter versus the 14 bps achieved in Q1. Operating efficiency remained strong with cost-to-average assets at a record-low 2.42 per cent, resulting in ROA/ROE of 0.96/13.61 per cent. CRAR stood at 17.03 per cent, providing adequate growth capital. The management expected GNPA below 2.50 per cent and NNPA below 1.00 per cent and business-model credit cost of 45-55 bps of average assets and a margin of safety of 3-4x (Q1 at 6.03x cost-to-average-assets of 2.50-2.60 per cent (Q1 at 2.42 per cent) and cost-to-income of 60 per cent or below. We maintain a Buy rating with a Target Price of ₹216, valuing the bank at 0.9x FY28E P/BV.

Systematix Shares

VIVASH SCIENTIFIC (BUY)

Target: ₹290
CMP: ₹259.85
Viyash Scientific's FY26 annual report highlights the successful integration of the erstwhile Viyash LifeSciences, Sequent Scientific and Appco Pharma businesses, with profitability supported by operational turnaround across key subsidiaries and an improving business mix. Appco Pharma (US) emerged as the single largest earnings driver, contributing nearly 40 per cent of consolidated profit following a sharp turnaround in profitability, while the Animal Health business witnessed broad-based improvement, with Alivira Animal Health significantly reducing losses. The company continued shifting its Human Formulations portfolio towards complex generics and differentiated products, supported by approximately 85 per cent backward integration across key products, while expanding its Companion Animal franchise through new product launches, strategic partnerships and dedicated R&D investments. Revenue quality improved with PLI incentives and licensing income contributing ₹60.90 crore. Manufacturing investments also continued, with the gross block increasing to ₹1,820 crore, while governance remained largely comfortable with no material related-party transactions involving KMP-controlled entities, although Dr Haribabu Bodepudi's remuneration of ₹78 crore and select transactions with Piramal Pharma and Aterna Labs Pvt represent key annual report observations. We retain Buy with a target price of ₹290.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

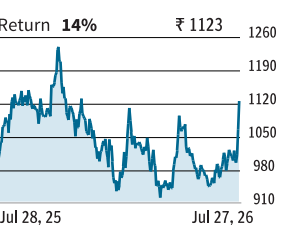
TODAY'S PICK.

PVR Inox (₹1,123.40): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for PVR Inox. The stock began the week on a strong note by surging over 5 per cent on Monday. This rise also gives an early confirmation of a triple bottom pattern formation on the chart. This is a bullish reversal pattern. Moving Average cross overs on the daily chart also strengthens the bullish case. Supports are at ₹1,100 and ₹1,070. The PVR Inox share price has potential to target ₹1,300 over the next couple of months. Traders can buy PVR Inox shares now at ₹1,123. Accumulate on dips at ₹1,105. Keep the

PVR Inox



stop-loss at ₹1,055. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹1,150 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹1,180. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹1,190 and ₹1,240 when the price touches ₹1,220 and ₹1,260, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹1,280.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24039 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23950	23880	24060	24170	Go long on a break above 24060. Keep the stop-loss at 24010

₹740 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
737	732	743	750	Go long only above 743. Stop-loss can be kept at 741

₹1078 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1065	1050	1085	1100	Take fresh longs above 1085 with a stop-loss at 1080

₹286 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
284	280	288	290	Can go either way from here. Avoid trading the stock

₹238 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
235	232	241	244	Wait for a rise. Go short at 240 with a stop-loss at 242

₹1282 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1275	1250	1290	1310	Go long only above 1290. Keep the stop-loss at 1285

₹1020 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1015	1000	1030	1050	Go short only below 1015. Keep the stop-loss at 1020

₹2296 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2280	2260	2315	2340	Wait for dips. Go long at 2285. Keep the stop-loss at 2270

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Infosys	1079.20	29.34	14.44	3.45	
Eternal Ltd.	295.85	25.03	659.37	1.95	
Bajaj Finance	1048.30	20.78	33.76	2.56	
ICICI Bank	1445.70	20.03	17.36	9.43	
M&M	3238.60	15.05	21.63	2.63	
IntGlobeAvi	5230.00	12.11	0.00	1.08	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1038.20	10.12	24.37	1.32	
TCS	2295.60	9.21	16.59	2.13	
Maruti Suzuki	13730.00	8.21	29.41	1.63	
Sun Pharma	1973.70	7.54	41.15	1.90	
Asian Paints	2710.20	7.14	59.15	1.12	
Hind Unilever	2174.60	5.74	48.28	1.76	
HCL Tech	1295.90	5.73	20.17	1.24	
Titan	4740.10	5.69	82.94	1.78	
Max Healthcare	1114.60	5.56	75.21	0.76	
L&T	3806.00	5.21	27.63	4.05	
State Bank	1020.60	5.06	10.87	3.84	
ITC	285.85	5.05	17.04	2.51	
Bharti Airtel	1905.30	4.72	34.32	5.27	
Bajaj Finserv	1913.00	4.59	15.57	1.01	
Eicher Motors	7769.50	4.26	38.67	0.97	
NTPC	350.80	3.73	12.35	1.51	
Trent Ltd.	2938.30	3.47	91.03	0.89	
Reliance Ind.	1280.00	2.95	19.65	7.87	
Tata Steel	184.25	2.85	21.13	1.39	
TataConsumerProduct	1107.40	2.76	70.85	0.66	
Tech Mahindra	1575.00	2.15	29.90	0.91	
Grasim Ind	3112.40	1.90	20.56	1.07	
Tata Motors PV	327.65	1.76	4022.27	0.82	
Bharat Elec	407.15	1.68	49.09	3.83	
Bajaj Auto	11183.50	1.29	27.06	1.13	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	236.17	1.05	75.46	0.71	
UltraTech Cement	11881.00	0.90	40.85	1.28	
Wipro	178.53	0.88	14.11	0.47	
Apollo Hosp	8843.50	0.85	63.50	0.83	
SBI Life	186.30	0.80	75.94	0.76	
JSW Steel	1244.60	0.78	10.87	1.06	
Hindalco	945.25	0.77	15.86	1.25	
Adani Enter	3036.60	0.64	39.70	0.80	
PowerGrid Corp	288.85	0.64	16.87	1.19	
NestleIndia	1446.10	0.61	73.17	0.94	
Adani Ports	1779.40	0.30	31.91	1.19	
Axis Bank	1227.50	0.13	13.67	3.21	
Coal India	427.50	0.05	8.48	0.93	
Dr Reddys Lab	1150.80	-0.12	30.17	0.64	
Cipla	1409.40	-0.15	33.93	0.72	
Kotak Bank	384.65	-0.16	18.85	2.58	
HDFC Life	552.85	-0.52	60.40	0.54	
ONGC	238.56	-0.65	6.02	0.84	
HDFC Bank	739.55	-10.87	13.80	10.31	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 830.85 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1785.20	76.44	29.08	3.09	
Divis Lab	7414.00	61.12	76.64	3.77	
Macrotech Developers	1198.70	44.02	34.91	1.33	
Samvardhanamaterialsint	148.97	43.91	38.48	2.63	
Pidilifind	1611.30	36.38	66.38	2.00	
Bpcl	316.25	35.93	8.01	2.57	
Power Finance	420.10	34.70	4.12	2.45	
Indian Oil Corp	141.52	33.12	4.58	2.12	
Gall (India)	174.23	33.00	15.11	1.88	
Jindal Steel	1065.70	32.19	32.35	1.58	
Tata Motors Cv	411.10	30.04	50.00	3.44	
Varun Beverages	464.50	29.01	4.85	2.54	
Hdfc Amc	2552.40	27.67	37.12	2.08	
Ltimindtree	4190.80	26.72	23.92	1.56	
HindustanAeronautics	4619.00	25.14	33.89	3.51	
Torrent Pharma	5019.50	24.72	89.30	2.95	
Rural Elec	368.15	23.78	5.94	1.84	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	377.90	19.13	115.46	2.41	
Godrej Consumer	170.73	16.58	59.02	1.73	
Bajaj Holdings	10810.00	16.48	12.29	1.87	
Indian Hotels Co.	733.75	16.08	45.24	2.58	
Canara Bank	272.26	15.72	6.46	1.71	
Tata Power	377.35	14.30	23.56	2.52	
Hyundai Motor India	1984.60	13.26	29.69	1.13	
United Spirits	1482.00	12.71	63.90	1.75	
Tata Capital	350.55	12.65	30.42	0.71	
Punjab Natl Bank	1116.22	12.41	5.80	1.54	
MuthuFin	3025.50	12.22	114.50	1.30	
Coimbatore Ind	567.00	11.38	66.02	2.04	
Dif	165.90	10.53	36.50	1.67	
Amulja Cements	430.95	10.51	19.48	1.08	
Solar Industries	18628.00	9.49	97.06	1.82	
Mazagon Dock	2330.30	8.06	34.11	0.71	
Siemens	3718.00	7.24	86.38	1.32	
Siemens Energy India	3264.60	6.27	88.76	1.16	
Adani Green	446.50	4.66	66.02	2.44	
AdaniRenewenergy	1399.70	4.48	107.43	1.88	
Yates Corp.	3876.40	4.23	51.14	3.65	
Avenuesuper	4027.70	4.17	85.92	2.60	
Adani Power	213.96	3.62	28.39	3.55	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	881.3	2.98	16.43	0.71	
Britannia Ind	1590.30	1.71	51.12	2.54	
AdaniEnergy Solutions	1703.20	1.05	66.02	2.44	
Vedanta	264.65	0.00	6.53	1.80	
Zydusfamilies	1108.20	-0.36	21.76	1.11	
Union Bank	170.11	-2.19	6.29	1.32	
Hindus Zinc	529.65	-3.21	16.18	1.02	
Abb India	73.75	-7.32	98.27	1.54	
Bosch	41250.00	-12.73	63.87	1.43	
Bank Of Baroda	244.00	-13.21	6.29	1.81	



CM
YK

QUICKLY.

Tata Chemicals Q1 profit down 81% to ₹60 crore



New Delhi: Tata Chemicals on Monday reported an 81 per cent decline in its net profit to ₹60 crore for the quarter ended June on higher expenses. Its net profit stood at ₹316 crore in the prior year. The company's total income rose to ₹4,311 crore in the first quarter of this fiscal from ₹3,815 crore in the corresponding period of the preceding year, according to a regulatory filing. [PM](#)

WRTL signs ECI pact for New Zealand solar project

Ahmedabad: Waaree Renewable Technologies Ltd (WRTL) on Monday said it has signed an Early Contractor Involvement agreement with a special purpose vehicle of a global independent power producer to build a utility-scale solar photovoltaic project integrated with a battery energy storage system in New Zealand. This will mark WRTL's entry into the Australia and New Zealand renewable energy market. [OUR BUREAU](#)

Beverage makers given 90 days to remove ‘energy drinks’ tag

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) is learnt to have given a timeline of about three months to beverage companies to remove “energy drinks” descriptors on labels of products registered under the caffeinated beverage category, sources said.

This comes after the food safety regulator issued notices to some beverage players over use of “energy drinks” descriptors pointing out that it has not notified any standards for “energy drinks” or similar products. It has also raised concerns over use of therapeutic and functional claims made by products marketed as energy drinks

In a meeting held last week, FSSAI officials are believed to have given a 90 day timeline to transition to removal of energy drink descriptors from the product labels, sources said.

The meeting was attended by industry body representatives, besides FDA officials of Assam, Rajasthan, Gujarat and Maharashtra. However, sources also said that a formal order is being awaited in this regard. Meanwhile,

Tata Sons FY26 net up 22%; AGM to consider Chandra’s reappointment

CONSISTENT GROWTH. The company had posted net profit of ₹26,231 crore last year

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Tata Sons reported 21.8 per cent rise in net profit to ₹31,961 crore in FY26 on the back of strong performances by established businesses, Chairman N Chandrasekaran said in the annual report on Monday.

Last year, the holding company of the Tata group had posted net profit of ₹26,231 crore. Total revenue grew 9.1 per cent on a year-on year basis to ₹42,367 crore.

At the aggregate level, the revenue of the Tata Group grew 7.8 per cent to ₹16,24,030 crore in FY26, while net profit grew 51.9 per cent to ₹1,70,525 crore.

“Revenue is 2.1x and profits are 5.4x their FY20 levels, reflecting sustained and significant turnaround efforts across the institution. All of our established businesses delivered strong performances this year, both in terms of revenue and profits,” Chandrasekaran wrote in his letter to shareholders.

The group’s aviation and



“All of our established businesses delivered strong performances this year, both in terms of revenue and profits

N CHANDRASEKARAN,
Chairman, Tata Sons

digital business, however, continued to be a drag on business. Air India’s loss widened from ₹10,859 crore to ₹22,238 crore in FY26.

Tata Digital was the second largest loss maker for the group its loss widening from ₹4,610 crore to ₹4,974

crore. Chandrasekaran defended the group’s investments in new businesses.

“Rebuilding Air India is a long journey: fleet renewal, training, service transformation, network expansion. Every great airline in history was built over decades, not

quarters,” he wrote.

Similarly on Tata Digital, he said the company has great ambitions are great and are beginning to show progress.

REAPPOINTMENT

Tata Sons will consider reappointing Chandrasekaran as group chairman at its annual general meeting on August 18.

Chandrasekaran, who is liable for retirement to retire by rotation, is seeking a reappointment for third time. In FY26, he received a remuneration of ₹158.66 crore. This included ₹17.97 crore in salary and compensation and ₹140.69 crore in commission.

The reappointment comes in the backdrop of litigation over composition and functioning of two Tata Trusts, which control around 66 per cent of shares in Tata Sons.

Sir Ratan Tata Trust has been unable to convene a trustee meeting following directions from the Charity Commissioner of Maharashtra. This dispute has also created some uncertainty about the conduct of the AGM.

Gartner forecasts 14.2% rise in global IT spending in 2026

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Worldwide IT spending is expected to rise by 14.2 per cent to \$6.37 trillion in 2026 from \$5.58 trillion in 2025, according to Gartner. In the latest forecast update, total IT spending has been revised upward with stronger growth projections, reflecting increased confidence in overall market expansion.

The revision places greater emphasis on AI-related spending, with incremental growth increasingly concentrated in segments directly benefiting from AI adoption, while traditional segments show comparatively modest changes. Data centre systems are expected to remain the fastest-growing segment. Spending on data centre systems is forecast to jump 62.5 per cent to \$822 billion in 2026, following a 51.6 per cent increase in 2025, underscoring sustained demand for AI servers and supporting infrastructure.

INVESTMENT IN AI

“Data centre systems and infrastructure as a service (IaaS) are the top growth segments, reflecting accelerating investment in AI infra-

Profit segment

	2025 Spending	2025 Growth (%)	2026 Spending	2026 Growth (%)
Data centre systems	506	51.6	822	62.5
Devices	790	9.7	868	9.8
Software	1,271	13.9	1,468	15.5
Services	1,492	3.8	1,570	5.3
Infrastructure as a service (IaaS)	222	25.3	287	29.3
Communications services	1,296	3.3	1,354	4.4
Overall IT	5,577	10.7	6,369	14.2

Source: Gartner (July 2026)

structure, cloud platforms and intelligent applications,” said John-David Lovelock, Distinguished VP Analyst at Gartner. He further said, “Building the compute capacity required for AI is the largest infrastructure project ever attempted by humanity. Driven by the expansion of AI workloads and demand for high-performance computing, hyper-scalers and enterprises are rapidly scaling next-generation data centre capacity.”

Beyond infrastructure, software spending is expected to grow 15.5 per cent to \$1.47 trillion, while IaaS is projected to increase 29.3 per cent to \$287 billion as enterprises expand cloud deployments. Devices spending is forecast to rise 9.8 per

cent to \$868 billion, services spending 5.3 per cent to \$1.57 trillion and communications services 4.4 per cent to \$1.35 trillion.

Gartner added that AI infrastructure, AI-enabled cloud platforms and advanced software ecosystems will remain the most attractive segments for capitalising on the strong expansion in global IT spending. “IT spending growth is being fuelled by rising investments in AI infrastructure and software. Organisations are spending more on AI-optimised servers, cloud services and AI-ready software as they expand their AI efforts, while hardware markets continue to adjust to semiconductor and memory supply constraints,” said Lovelock.

LPG-DME blending has downsides of material compatibility, safety: Govt

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Even as there are some commercial applications of blending dimethyl ether (DME) with LPG globally, there are certain downsides such as material compatibility, safety and lower calorific value of the former, Parliament was informed on Monday.

The government is aware of a potential pathway of blending of DME with liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), said the Minister of State for the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG) Suresh Gopi in a written response in the Rajya Sabha.

“While some experiments, pilot projects and limited commercial applications of DME-LPG blending have been undertaken globally, there are downsides of material compatibility, safety, handling, and regulatory requirements and lower calorific value than LPG,” the Minister added.

PROCUREMENT PLAN

Presently, there is no proposal under consideration to formulate a national DME blending policy or to provide fiscal incentives or viability gap funding specifically for DME production for LPG blending, Gopi said.

“Similarly, no procure-



CAUTIOUS STANCE. MoS Suresh Gopi speaking in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon Session on Monday [ANI](#)

ment programme for DME by PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) has been finalised,” the Minister added.

According to the Council of Scientific & Industrial Research (CSIR), DME is a promising fuel that is both sustainable and eco-friendly. It is a synthetically produced alternative fuel that can be directly used in specially designed compression ignition diesel engines for various purposes. Under normal atmospheric conditions, DME is a colourless gas.

DME can be considered as a ‘Second Generation fuel/bio-fuel’ with a slight ethereal odour. It is used extensively in the chemical industry and as an aerosol propellant, solvent, fuel, and refrigerant. DME exhibits

comparable calorific value and similarity of its thermal efficiency to traditional fuels. It is a clean-burning fuel with low emission and low particulate matter.

LPG CONSUMPTION

India imports about 60 per cent of its LPG consumption, out of which about 90 per cent transits through the Strait of Hormuz. In view of the conflict in West Asia, the availability of imported LPG in the country has been impacted. LPG prices are linked to its prices in the international market. While prices of commercial LPG are set by LPG marketing companies independently, the government continues to modulate the effective price to consumers for domestic LPG.

Infosys fined €175,000 by French labour authority

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Infosys has been fined €175,000 or around ₹2 crore, by a French labour authority, DRIETS Ile-de-France, for failing to ensure its employee working time recording system fully complied with local legal requirements, according to a regulatory filing by the company on Saturday. Infosys said it received the communication from the authority on July 24.

“The authority found that Infosys’ working time recording system did not fully comply with French legal requirements, citing shortcomings in its reliability, auditability and monitoring capabilities for certain employee categories,” the firm said in the filing. Infosys said the fine would have no material impact on its financials, operations or other business activities.

“The company was in the process of checking the veracity and determining further steps, upon receipt of communication,” Infosys added. It did not disclose whether it intends to challenge the order. The latest penalty adds to a handful of labour- and compliance-related issues Infosys has faced before.

‘AI data centres to consume 26.3 GW electricity by FY32’

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The Power Ministry expects Artificial Intelligence (AI)-powered data centres to consume around 26.3 gigawatts (GW) of electricity by FY22, which will primarily be served by renewable energy.

India’s Electric Power Survey (EPS) is regularly conducted by the Central Electricity Authority (CEA) every five years for estimating the electricity demand of the country, said Minister of State for Power Shripad Yesso Naik in a written response to a query in the Rajya Sabha.

“An additional load of 26.3 GW from artificial intelligence data centres is projected by 2031-32, which is expected to be integrated into the grid and primarily served by renewable energy capacity,” he added. Per the National Electricity Plan (NEP), installed generation capacity in 2031-32 is likely to be 874 GW.

The Minister emphasised that the development of transmission infrastructure is also being undertaken in a phased manner, commensurate with the growing electricity demand and planned generation capacity addition, including renewable energy.

The NEP envisages development of the transmission

system with an estimated investment of about ₹9,16,142 crore during the plan period (2022-32), he added.

Grid modernisation measures, including deployment of static synchronous compensator, battery energy storage systems, synchronous condensers and other advanced grid support technologies are also being planned to enhance grid reliability, flexibility and facilitate integration of renewable energy, Naik informed the Upper House.

THERMAL CAPACITY

The government is also adding more thermal power capacity to manage base load for grid stability. The projected thermal (coal and lignite) capacity requirement by the year FY36 is estimated at around 3,15,000 MW as against the 2,11,855 MW installed capacity as on March 31, 2023.

To meet this requirement, the Ministry has envisaged to set up an additional minimum 1,05,000 MW coal and lignite-based thermal capacity.

Of this, thermal capacities of around 21,080 MW have been commissioned from April 2023 till June 30, 2026. In addition, 47,545 MW of thermal capacity is currently under construction. The contracts of 16,000 MW have been awarded and are due for construction.

Avis India plans ₹550 cr FY27 capex, targets ₹700 cr revenue

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Driven by corporate leasing, premium chauffeur-driven rentals and a shift towards organised fleet providers, Avis India — the Indian joint venture backed by Nasdaq-listed Avis Budget Group and The Oberg Group — plans to raise capital expenditure by 175 per cent to ₹550 crore in FY27 from ₹200 crore in FY26. It is also targeting a 31 per cent increase in revenue to ₹700 crore from ₹535.5 crore.

“Last year, our capex was ₹200 crore. This year, it will be close to ₹550 crore,” Aman Naagar, Managing Director, Avis India, told *businessline*. “We have grown the business at about 20 per cent year-on-year,” he said. Avis Budget Group indirectly owns 60 per cent of Avis India, while EIH Ltd, the listed flagship of The Oberg Group, holds 40 per cent.

Avis operates about 12,000 vehicles, comprising nearly 3,000 cars in its rental business and 9,000 under operating leases. Its rental net-



We control the customer experience end to end — whether it is the car, the chauffeur or the service back-end

AMAN NAAGAR
MD, Avis India

work spans 47 locations across 20 cities, while leasing extends across about 70 cities. The two businesses have more than 500 corporate clients.

CARE RATINGS

Its leasing fleet has expanded about 45 per cent from 6,188 vehicles as of January 2025 to nearly 9,000 currently. Leases generally run for three to five years, allowing companies and employees to upgrade vehicles without assuming ownership and resale risks. “As far as leasing is concerned, it depends on the customer profile and the kind of car the customer wants to lease,” Naagar said. CARE Ratings has previ-



ously put its average vehicle-disposal age at 46-48 months. Proceeds from selling used cars exceeded ₹400 crore cumulatively over the five years through FY24, helping fund fleet renewal.

Unlike mobility companies that source most vehicles from local vendors, Avis owns its assets to control availability, maintenance and service quality. “We believe in putting the metal on the road because that brings consistency in our service,” Naagar said. He added, “We control the customer experience end to end — whether it is the car, the chauffeur or the service back-end.” The capital programme will be funded through internal ac-

cruals and bank borrowings. Naagar said the company had a debt-to-equity ratio of around 1.6 per cent. Avis estimates India’s corporate mobility market, including employee transportation, at close to \$2 billion and expects it to reach \$10-12 billion by 2031. Business travel, events and new global capability centres are expected to support demand.

DEMAND SHIFT

“There are new customers we have acquired and customers who have shifted their requirements from local operators to an organised, structured player,” Naagar said. The rental fleet is led by the Toyota Innova Crysta and Honda City, with the Mercedes-Benz E-Class offering the luxury offering.

Avis owns about 150 Mercedes-Benz cars, which he said made it the country’s largest organised E-Class rental-fleet owner. Mahindra vehicles are seeing the strongest leasing demand, although he did not identify individual models.

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AHMEDABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
(BRIDGE PROJECT DEPARTMENT)
E - Tender Notice
Expression of Interest (EOI)

Sr. No	Name of Work
1.	EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) For BRIDGE HEALTH MONITORING SYSTEM FOR THE WORK OF INSTALLATION, COMMISSIONING AND OPERATION OF BRIDGE HEALTH MONITORING SYSTEM (BHMS) FOR VARIOUS BRIDGES IN AHMEDABAD CITY.

Bid Available for Downloading : Dt. 29/07/2026
Date of Bid Opening : Dt. 02/09/2026
Details and Website available on : www.tender.nprocure.com
DY. MUNICIPAL COMMISSIONER (BRIDGE PROJECT)

SOLAPUR MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, SOLAPUR
(UNDER AMRUT MISSION)
E-Tender Notice No. 03 for 2026-2027 [IVth Call]

Commissioner, Municipal Corporation, Solapur invites B-1 E-Tender for the work of ATAL MISSION for Underground Drainage Scheme under Amrut Programme. Designing, Providing, erecting, commissioning & giving satisfactory test & trial of Fresh Electric Power supply work with its allied equipments at C.S.No-40/2/8,66/2 Desai Nagar STP in the State of Maharashtra, valued at Rs.119.00 Lakhs. The e-Tender details are available on www.mahatenders.gov.in from date- 27/07/2026

All relevant dates will be as per the tender published in web portal www.mahatenders.gov.in.
Tender ID:- **2026_SMC_1321834_1**

Sd/-
Additional Commissioner
Solapur Municipal Corporation, Solapur

TATA POWER
(Contracts Department)
Jojobera Generation Plant, RAHARGORAH, JAMSHEDPUR-831016, Jharkhand

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

The Tata Power Company Limited invites expression of interest from eligible vendors for the package Name

S.No.	Tender Description	Ref No
1	Operational support service for Side Stream Filtration Plant (SSF) (Powerhouse-7,IEL, Sakchi, Jamshedpur)	CC27PSJOJO-01
2	Construction of the Permanent Store at PH #7 (Powerhouse-7,IEL, Sakchi, Jamshedpur)	CC27SMJOJO-01
3	Operation Support Services for RO-DM plant at PH#06 (Inside Tata Steel Premises)- Jamshedpur	CC27PSJOJO-04

For details of pre-qualification requirements, bid security, purchasing of tender document etc., please visit Tender section of our website ([URL: https://www.tatapower.com/tender](https://www.tatapower.com/tender)). Eligible vendors willing to participate may submit their expression of interest along with the tender fee for issue of bid document latest by **11th August '26**.

QUICKLY.

Gold rises as oil retreats on pause in US-Iran strikes



Gold rose on Monday, as a pause in hostilities between the US and Iran sent crude oil prices to a one-week low, easing inflation concerns ahead of the US interest rate decision this week. Spot gold gained 0.9 per cent to \$4,087.59 per ounce by 09.43 am EDT, while US gold futures for August delivery rose 0.5 per cent to \$4,090. The US dollar index softened 0.1 per cent, making bullion more affordable for buyers overseas. REUTERS

Copper prices gain on lull in West Asia war

London: Copper prices rose on Monday as oil prices fell after the US and Iran suspended hostilities, easing concerns about price pressures and global economic growth. Benchmark copper on the London Metal Exchange was up 0.6 per cent at \$13,729 a tonne at 1427 GMT. “The market is now waiting for resolution, and it is trying to price in peace rather than an ongoing war,” said Panmure Liberum analyst Tom Price. REUTERS

Palm oil slips more than 1% on weaker crude oil

Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures fell more than 1 per cent on Monday, retreating from a 15-week high in the previous session, weighed down by weaker crude oil and Chinese vegetable oil prices, though robust demand from China capped the decline. The benchmark palm oil contract for October delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange slid 49 ringgit, or 1.04 per cent, to 4,673 ringgit (\$1,144.50) a tonne at the close. REUTERS

To cut import dependence on urea, Govt allows ammonia for farming

AGRI BOOST. If successful, India will be the fourth country after the US, Canada and Australia to use it directly

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Amid high demand and limited availability of urea, which contains 46 per cent nitrogen (N), the government has allowed ammonia, containing 82 per cent N, for agricultural use. However, the country will have to establish the infrastructure for the delivery and application of the gas, as it needs to be injected into the soil.

Industry sources said if successful, India will be the fourth country, after the US, Canada and Australia, to use ammonia directly in farming. According to a notification published on July 23, the Union Agriculture Ministry said “anhydrous ammonia” fertilizer, containing a minimum of 82 per cent nitrogen by weight, is allowed to be manufactured by any unit for a period of three years from



LAST MILE. The country has a long way to go in building infra needed to deliver and inject ammonia directly into fields

the date of the gazette notification, under clause 20A of the Fertilizer (Inorganic, Organic or Mixed) (Control) Order, 1985.

SULPHUR-COATED UREA “Permitting the use is good as it is the first step. However, implementing it is the key challenge due to the risks involved, particularly the possibility of gas leaks,” said a top official of a urea manu-

facturing company. Citing the example of sulphur-coated urea, he explained how there is hardly any actual use for the fertilizer though it was given regulatory clearance for manufacturing and sales. “Nowhere in the world is sulphur coated in prilled urea (the subsidised nitrogen product in India) as it is not suitable. Only in granular urea, sulphur can be coated,

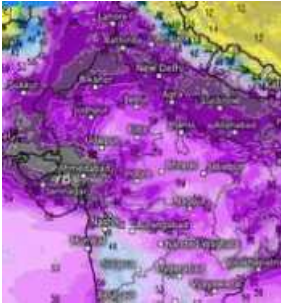
With a comeback, monsoon may upend forecasts of July fade-out

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

The monsoon may go to upend forecasts of a July fade-out, staging an emphatic comeback on the back of a relentless succession of Bay of Bengal low-pressure systems, almost recreating the season’s peak wet spell earlier this month. The signs of revival came on Monday when a low-pressure area over the north-west Bay of Bengal intensified within two to three days into a deep depression, a rarity during the season and just one rung below a tropical cyclone. The strengthening flies in the face of expecta-

tions that a building El Nino would sap the monsoon’s vigour through July.

RENEWED BURST The renewed burst of activity sharply improved the national rainfall picture. Cumulative rainfall across India until Sunday stood at a deficit of 15 per cent, with Central India almost back to normal at minus 3 per cent and North-West India at minus 8 per cent. East and North-East India improved to a deficit of 29 per cent, matching that of the South Peninsula. According to India Meteorological Department norms, rainfall between 19 per cent above normal and 19 per cent below normal is



ECMWF forecasts very heavy to extreme rain over north-west India, especially north Gujarat, till weekend

classified as “normal”. But the resurgent monsoon triggered floods and related havoc in Assam. The Assam State Disaster Management Authority said the floods had

Open market rice sale norms will likely help meet 20% ethanol blending target

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

The Centre’s revised standard operating procedure (SOP) for the sale of rice to ethanol distilleries for 2026-27 supply year (ESY) will ensure meeting the 20 per cent ethanol blending target, while utilising aged stocks better, say trade experts. “Earlier, old rice had limited commercial value. Now, it has become an industrial raw material for ethanol,” said New Delhi-based exporter Rajesh Paharia Jain. Earlier this month, the government fixed ₹2,320 per quintal for rice to be supplied for manufacturing ethanol till October 31. From November 1, it will be supplied at ₹2,390 per quintal. In addition, the Food Ministry has set aside 7.2 mil-



STOCK SURGE. The government has allocated an additional 5.5 mt of 100% broken rice for sale through e-auction

lion tonnes (mt) from FCI stocks for distilleries for the 2026-27 season. Last year, the Ministry allocated 5.5 mt.

RECORD STOCKS The government has allocated an additional 5.5 mt of 100 per cent broken rice for sale through e-auction. Ethanol producers can also procure this, potentially making biofuel production more profitable, according to in-

dustrial sources. The decision comes on the heels of the FCI holding a record 40.3 mt of rice and paddy, which could yield 38.74 mt of rice. FCI warehouses are overflowing with rice and wheat stocks after a record harvest in the 2025-26 crop year that ended in June. While rice production is estimated at a new high of 154 mt, wheat output has been pegged at 120.6 mt. The

FCI has 52.2 mt of wheat stocks, a five-year high.

BHARAT BRAND SUPPORT Jain said the surplus rice stocks could be liquidated systematically while maintaining buffer norms. A transparent e-auction system will improve price discovery, while a separate allocation for ethanol provides long-term feedstock security.

“Priority to old and broken rice minimises wastage and improves inventory turnover,” he said, adding that support for the Bharat brand will help stabilise retail prices and ensure food security. New Delhi-based trade analyst S Chandrasekaran said the OMSS policy should be seen beyond commodity with the perspective of a holistic economic scenario and administering social welfare.

Shriram Farm Solutions ties up with IIVR for breeder seeds

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Shriram Farm Solutions, a division of DCM Shriram Ltd, has signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Indian Council of Agricultural Research-Indian Institute of Vegetable Research (ICAR-IIVR), Varanasi, for the transfer of breeder seeds for five vegetable crops. These are radish, spinach, pea, cowpea and okra. The MoU was signed on the occasion of the 98th Foundation Day of ICAR, in the presence of Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare Shivraj Singh Chouhan. The agreement will provide Shriram Farm Solutions access to advanced vegetable breeding research and breeder seed material developed by ICAR-IIVR. Through this partnership,

Shriram Farm Solutions will work towards translating scientific research into improved seed varieties suited to Indian farmers.

YIELD FOCUS A statement said that access to breeder seeds is expected to strengthen the company’s vegetable seed development programme and support the introduction of varieties focused on quality, productivity, resilience and consistency across diverse growing conditions. Sanjay Chhabra, Business Head, Shriram Farm Solutions, said, “Our partnership with ICAR-IIVR provides access to breeding material that will strengthen our vegetable seed portfolio. By combining the research excellence of ICAR-IIVR with our product development capabilities, we aim to deliver high-performing seed solutions.”

Crude oil slides as supply threats ease in West Asia

Bloomberg

Crude oil sank as the US paused almost two weeks of daily strikes against Iran and tankers sailed to load at Kazakh export terminal, easing supply pressures. Brent crude steadied around \$90 a barrel after tumbling more than 9 per cent early in the session to trade below \$88 a barrel. West Texas Intermediate also declined. Oil markets dipped as the US has apparently held off on new strikes since late Friday, following 13 straight nights of attacks aimed at degrading Iran’s ability to disrupt commercial shipping. Iran signalled it was refraining from any retaliation and held talks with Oman over the Strait of Hormuz, though Saudi Arabia said it intercepted drones from Iraq targeting its oil facilities.

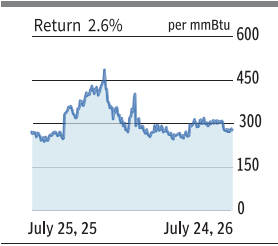
Open fresh short positions in natural gas futures

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Natural gas futures, which were charting a sideways trend recently, have breached the nearest notable support, opening the door for a further decline. July futures are now trading at ₹263/mmBtu, and the August contract at ₹268. Since the July contract will expire on Tuesday (July 28), we shall consider the August futures for analysis.

COMMODITY CALL.

August futures breached a support at ₹272 on Monday after witnessing a consolidation between ₹272 and ₹285 in the preceding sessions. Thus, they are likely to see another leg of decline. The nearest support level can be spotted at ₹255, followed by another at ₹250.



In case the contract rallies, it will face resistance at ₹272 and ₹285. For natural gas futures (Aug) to turn the outlook positive, it ought to break out of ₹285. In this case, it could rise to ₹300, a barrier. Overall, as it stands, the outlook is bearish.

TRADE STRATEGY We had suggested shorting natural gas futures at an average price of ₹280. Since the July contract is set to expire, traders can exit and open a fresh short position in August futures at ₹268. Target and stop-loss can be ₹255 and ₹268, respectively.

With 71% of kharif area covered, sowing deficit shrinks below 5%

Kharif sowing*			
	2025	2026	% change
Paddy	240.62	234.43	-2.6
Pulses	91.46	84.57	-7.5
Shri Anna cum coarse cereals	161.49	142.21	-11.9
Oilseeds	167	163.54	-2.1
Cotton	102.71	98.72	-3.9
All crops	826.19	787.38	-4.7

Source: Agriculture Ministry (*Area as of July 24; in lakh hectare)

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

With over 3 lakh hectares (lh) more sown in the past week compared to the same period a year ago, farmers have reduced the kharif acreage deficit to less than 5 per cent, down from a high of 21 per cent as of July 5. Agriculture scientists are hopeful of avoiding any major negative impact on overall crops despite the emergence of El Nino, as over 71 per cent of sowing has been completed. However, rainfall in the next two months will need to be closely monitored as it is crucial for crop growth. The sowing area in the ongoing kharif season has reached 787.38 lh as of July 24 compared with 826.19 lh in the year-ago period, down by 4.7 per cent, the Agriculture Ministry said in its weekly update on Monday. As many as 129.19 lh was covered under kharif sowing during the July 18-24 period against only 125.72 lh a year ago.

MADHYA PRADESH AREA DOWN SHARPLY The kharif season’s main cereal paddy is down by 2.6 per cent at 234.43 lh against 240.62 lh a year ago. Official sources said paddy acreage in top grower Uttar Pradesh is 4 per cent higher at 57.8 lh from 55.46 lh, Punjab at 31.66 lh from 31.56 lh, Bihar at 17.58 lh from 12.89

lh, Assam at 11.68 lh from 6.76 lh and Andhra Pradesh at 4.74 lh from 4.46 lh. Madhya Pradesh reported a major dip in paddy area at 19.54 lh from 27.39 lh and Maharashtra at 4.9 lh from 8.59 lh, whereas other States with lower areas included Chhattisgarh (-0.9 lh), West Bengal (-0.9 lh), Haryana (-1.2 lh), Telangana (-0.5 lh) and Odisha (-1.6 lh). The area under all pulses reached 84.57 lakh hectares (lh) compared to 91.46 lakh hectares, and that of oilseeds reached 147.09 lakh hectares compared to 155.72 lakh hectares. The deficit in pulses has declined to 7.5 per cent from 23 per cent as of July 10, and in oilseeds, it has decreased to 2 per cent from 21 per cent during the same period. Among pulses, arhar sowing reached 31.17 lh, down 12 per cent from 35.27 lh, moong (green gram) at 26.89 lh from 28.39 lh and urad (black gram) rose to 18.67 lh from 17.27 lh. In oilseeds, soybean is down to 113.65 lh from 117.24 lh, and groundnut to 40.2 lh from 40.77 lh. Cotton acreage is now 4 per cent lower at 98.72 lh from 102.71 lh. The coverage of nutri/coarse cereals has been reported to be 12 per cent lower. The area under jowar reached 11.07 lh, down from 12.45 lh a year ago, while bajra decreased to 49.54 lh, ragi dropped to 1.56 lh and maize fell to 77.79 lh.

August-September rain to decide 2026-27 pulses crop size as kharif sowing picks up

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The kharif pulses crop size will eventually depend on rainfall during August and September rather than on the extent of area sown, according to India Pulses and Grains Association (IPGA) Chairman Bimal Kothari. Pulses sowing picked up in recent weeks, but the overall acreage is still trailing last year’s levels. “As of now, there are no major concerns or complaints. We received rainfall from early July, and then rainfall resumed around July 18-19. Since then, there has been a good amount of rain across most parts of the country. The only exception appears to be Karnataka, where there are still some issues. Earlier, there was a de-



Bimal Kothari, Chairman, IPGA

ficit in sowing of pulses, but that has now been largely recovered. The deficit is mainly in tur (pigeon pea), but with the ongoing rain, it is expected to recover. Urad acreage has improved significantly. Therefore, as far as sowing numbers are concerned, there does not appear to be any significant shortfall now. The situation has largely been addressed. However,

the key factor to watch is the rainfall during August-September,” Kothari said. The IPGA Chairman said that while adequate rainfall is essential for the crops to mature, according to the IMD forecast, rainfall during August and September is projected to be below normal. “If sufficient rainfall does not occur in the key crop-growing areas in August, it could adversely affect the crops that have already been sown. Having said that, I think it is still premature to draw any conclusion,” he said. On the supply side, Kothari said the supply is plenty, and a lot of pulses are selling below the minimum support price (MSP). “I don’t think there is any concern. While prices of other food products such as sugar and edible oils have increased, the prices of pulses are stable. Rather, it has declined since April, and there is no positive contribution of pulses to food inflation,” he said. Similarly, the crop size for

period last year), while urad has been sown on 18.67 lh (17.27 lh). Moong bean acreage was 26.87 lh (28.39 lh). “While below-normal rainfall may appear concerning, moderate showers at the right time could actually benefit the crop by avoiding harvest time damage. As of now, however, I do not see any major cause for concern,” he said. On the supply side, Kothari said the supply is plenty, and a lot of pulses are selling below the minimum support price (MSP). “I don’t think there is any concern. While prices of other food products such as sugar and edible oils have increased, the prices of pulses are stable. Rather, it has declined since April, and there is no positive contribution of pulses to food inflation,” he said.



pounded by a sharp rise in competition from Brazil and the African countries, has significantly dampened domestic demand. To worsen the situation, actual production far exceeded the crop size limits set by the Board.

GLUT FORCES CUT With the situation going out of control, the Board recently decided to cut the crop size to 81 million kg for Andhra Pradesh against 142 million kg (mkg), a pruning of 43 per cent for the 2026-27 season. Similarly, the crop size for

Karnataka has been reduced to 51 mkg for 2026-27 against 100 mkg last year, a 44 per cent cut. The Board, which works under the Union Commerce Ministry, is mandated to regulate production and curing of FCV (flue-cured tobacco) to ensure remunerative prices to growers. It evaluates the market conditions globally and takes a call on the crop size every year. Excessive production from licenced growers attracts penalties during the auctions. “We understand the rationale. We are aware that there is a glut. We want the government to come out with a strategy to help farmers identify alternative crops,” PS Murali Babu, President and former General Secretary of the Federation of All India Farmer Associations (FAIFA), told businessline.

QUICKLY.

**Dr Reddy's, GARDP get
Thai nod for Nuzolvence**



Hyderabad: The Global Antibiotic Research and Development Partnership (GARDP) Foundation and Dr Reddy's Laboratories have secured approval from the Thai Food and Drug Administration for Nuzolvence (zofludacin). Nuzolvence is indicated for the treatment of uncomplicated urogenital gonorrhoea in adults and patients 12 years of age and older, weighing at least 35 kg. **OUR BUREAU**

**Bristol Myers Squibb
launches Relopduo**

Mumbai: American drugmaker Bristol Myers Squibb is bringing its Relopduo, a fixed-dose combination of nivolumab and relatlimab, to India, the company said, adding that it was the first to get approval for an FDC of two immune checkpoint inhibitors. **OUR BUREAU**

Centre's Bill proposes up to 10 years jail, ₹10 cr fine for exam paper leaks

STRICTER PUNISHMENT. Bill seeks fast-track courts, penalties for service providers and organised exam fraud

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The government on Monday introduced a Bill to amend the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, with provisions for jail terms of up to 10 years and a penalty of up to ₹10 crore for individuals or entities found guilty in paper-leak cases.

Amid protests by the Opposition, the Bill was moved by Minister of State in the Prime Minister's Office, Jitendra Singh. Although Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla called out the names of various members of the Opposition benches to express their opinion on the introduction of the Bill, none responded.

Later, Birla assured the members that they would have enough time to share their views and suggestions during the debate on the Bill. However, the Bill could not be taken for consideration and passage on Monday itself.



BIG CHANGES. Minister of State Jitendra Singh speaking in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon Session on Monday **ANI**

The present law prescribes a jail term of 3-5 years and a fine of up to ₹10 lakh for any person or persons who resort to unfair means or commit offences in public examinations.

STRICTER PUNISHMENT Now, the Bill proposes a minimum jail term of 5 years and a maximum of 10 years, with a fine of up to ₹50 lakh.

Similarly, the service provider found guilty will be liable to a fine of up to ₹5 crore, as against ₹1 crore at present. Also, the service

provider will be debarred from conducting examinations for 8 years, as against the present provision of 4 years.

Another provision in the new Bill prescribed that where it is established during the investigation that an offence under this Act has been committed with the consent or connivance of any Director, Senior Management or the persons in charge of the service provider firm, he shall be liable for imprisonment for a term not less than 5 years, as

against the present provision of 3 years. The jail term may be extended to 10 years. Also, it is proposed to increase the fine to ₹5 crore from ₹1 crore. In the event of default in payment of the fine, an additional punishment of imprisonment shall be imposed as per the provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023.

FAST-TRACK TRIALS

The Bill proposes that if a person or a group of persons, including the examination authority, service provider or any other institution commits an organised crime, he shall be punished with imprisonment for a term not less than 7 years, as against the present provision of 5 years.

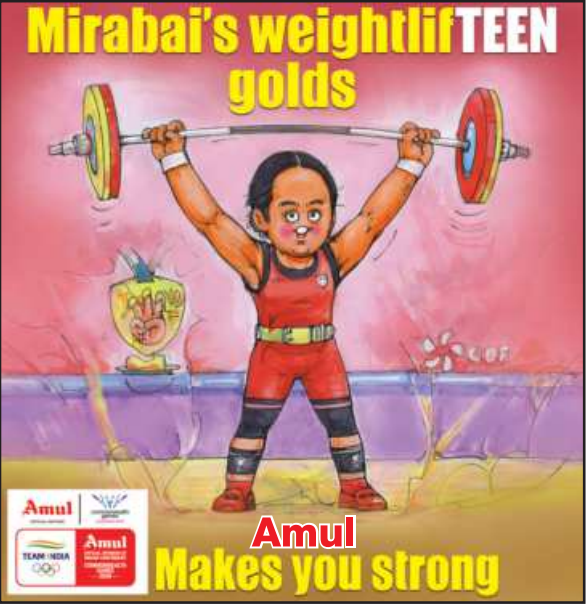
The amount of funds will be ₹10 crore, up from ₹1 crore. Here too, in the event of default in payment of the fine, an additional punishment of imprisonment shall be imposed as per the provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The Bill proposes to empower all State Governments and Union Territory Administrations to designate any Court of Session as a Special Fast Track Court to try offences under the said Act. The proceedings in such Special Fast Track Courts are continued on a day-to-day basis, and the trial shall be completed within 3 months from the date of filing of the charge sheet. The Centre will be empowered to constitute a Special Task Force to investigate any offence, if necessary.

APPEAL MECHANISM

The Bill proposes that the investigations be completed within two months. One or more Special Public Prosecutors for the conduct of cases can be appointed.

The Bill also provides for an appeal mechanism against any judgment, sentence or order to a bench of two judges of the High Court, for its disposal within 3 months from the date of admission of appeal.



Centre reviews DGCA's airline approval timeline

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Centre is reviewing whether the Directorate General of Civil Aviation's (DGCA) approval process for launching scheduled airlines can be streamlined as part of a broader overhaul of India's aviation regulatory framework aimed at lowering entry barriers and encouraging more private players, sources told *businessline*.

The move follows the government's wider review of regulations governing airline entry. Last week, *businessline* reported that the Centre had identified several hurdles, including the 0/20 rule, that make it difficult for corporates to set up airlines.

Officials familiar with the deliberations said policymakers are examining licensing procedures, security clearances, minimum capital requirements and manpower-related regulations. The focus is on the current multi-stage approval process under which airlines must sequentially obtain a no-objection certificate (NOC), security clearance and an Air

Operator Certificate (AOC) before commencing commercial operations.

APPROVALS PROCESS

The Ministry of Civil Aviation is assessing whether these procedures can be rationalised without diluting regulatory safeguards. According to sources, the sequential approvals often delay commercial launches and impose significant compliance costs before airlines begin earning revenue.

The government is also reviewing rules governing ownership changes, management restructuring and corporate approvals. At present, airlines are required to obtain fresh regulatory and security clearances following significant changes in ownership a process that can slow fundraising.

The Ministry is also examining the minimum paid-up capital norms prescribed for scheduled airlines based on fleet size and aircraft. Sources said the existing thresholds may no longer reflect the realities of an industry dependent on aircraft leasing and new financing models.

'Digital ID use in exams can help curb impersonation'

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

The examination processes in our country should be more technology-savvy and we will look to apply learnings on technology use from large multi-session exams like JEE to other examinations, V Kamakoti, Director, IIT-Madras, said on Monday. The use of digital identity verification methods can also help eliminate issues such as impersonation during examinations, he added.

Kamakoti, who has been



V Kamakoti, Director, IIT-Madras **BIJOU GHOSH**

nominated as a member of the Prime Minister's newly constituted High Power Task Force on National Testing Agency (NTA) reforms, was speaking to *businessline* on his role in the panel.

"NEET could not be made computerised because there was a need for it to be on single session and on a single common platform where all the students are evaluated. But if like JEE, if you're going for multi-session, then it can become computer-based and hence could solve some of the problems," he said in a chat.

ENSURING INTEGRITY

He explained that in the JEE Mains, there are about 10 sessions of exams that are conducted with about four different papers and a good way has been devised to nor-

malize the evaluation across this.

Kamakoti also stressed that in the recent instance of the NEET paper leaks, the lapse was not during the physical transition/distribution phase between centres, but it was an issue of compromised "roots of trust" in paper-setting structures. We will also explore the use of technology to ensure that the integrity of the question paper setting is maintained, he said.

Interestingly, he also bats for digital identity verification systems to ensure there is no impersonation is-

ssues among students appearing for examinations. "We have already been trying this out in JEE Advanced on a preliminary basis," he added.

While the high profile task force has not had its first meeting yet, Kamakoti expects that they will work on a short-term, medium-term priorities basis and recommend reforms and work with the government to see that there are certain structures and regulations in place to drive them.

EVALUATION PROCESS

Measures already taken like

fast-track courts and monitoring vulnerabilities on platforms like Telegram are crucial to addressing fake/real leaks, he said.

Speaking of the need for transparency in the evaluation process, he said that true transparency involves providing students with clear insight into how their marks were evaluated either in the form of copies of OMR sheets, response sheets, and by ensuring robust re-evaluation processes.

"AI may assist in spotting anomalies or evaluation of errors, but human-in-the-loop is essential," he added.

Supreme Court to seek exam reform task force's inputs on online NEET exam

Aaratrika Bhaumik
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday indicated that it would seek suggestions from the high-powered task force, to be headed by former UIDAI Chairman Nandan Nilekani, on transitioning the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test for Undergraduate (NEET-UG) to a computer-based test (CBT). A Bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe was hearing a petition filed by RJD MP Sudhakar Singh seeking sweeping reforms in the conduct of the NEET-UG examination, including a direction to examine a transition from the existing pen-and-paper format to a com-

puter-based test. The petition was filed after the Union government and the National Testing Agency (NTA) cancelled the NEET-UG 2026 examination held on May 3 following allegations of a widespread paper leak.

SERIOUS VIEW

During the hearing, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, informed the Bench that the Union government had taken a "very serious view" of the matter and had constituted a high-powered task force. Justice Narasimha said the court would hear the matter on August 3 along with the other pending petitions on NEET reforms. He added that the court would

The SC had directed the Centre to file an additional affidavit outlining its road map for implementing the reforms, detailing the proposed cybersecurity framework

seek the task force's views on how the transition from the present pen-and-paper format to a computer-based examination could be carried out and the safeguards required to secure examination data. Earlier, the Bench

had called out extraordinary measures, such as deploying the Indian Air Force to transport question papers of this year's NEET examination, as temporary fixes. "We cannot let such a situation go on like this. We have to focus on institutionalisation... Here, because of what had happened, you deployed the Air Force, but that is only an ad hoc arrangement, not a permanent one," the Bench had observed.

The top court had also directed the Centre to file an additional affidavit outlining its road map for implementing the reforms, detailing the proposed cybersecurity framework, the designated agency for its implementation, and the safeguards to prevent data breaches.

SC says peaceful protest constitutional, mulls framing police conduct guidelines

Aaratrika Bhaumik
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday observed that the constitutional right to peaceful protest must be protected and indicated that it may consider framing uniform guidelines to regulate police conduct during large-scale demonstrations.

A Bench led by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said it was equally concerned about injuries suffered by both protesters and police personnel during such protests, and stressed that "self-imposed discipline" on the part of both citizens and law enforcement was essential to the functioning of a democracy.



"The right to peaceful protest is absolutely guaranteed under the Constitution. So long as it is a peaceful agitation, merely because there is agitation, there cannot be [police excesses]... If there is police excess committed, it should be independently examined," the Chief Justice orally remarked.

The oral observations came as multiple petitions concerning the nationwide

protests over examination paper leaks were mentioned before the Bench, which also comprised Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana. These included petitions alleging police excesses during the July 20 Parliament march led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), as well as those concerning the alleged "aerial firing" by police personnel in Bihar's Siwan during the Bihar bandh on Saturday (July 25, 2026).

Following the protests, which spread across several States, Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as the Union Education Minister on Saturday.

Advocate Fauzia Shakil, appearing for Rajya Sabha member Manoj Jha, told the court that a comprehensive writ petition had been filed

placing on record material relating to the police action.

PROTECT POLICE

On Monday, senior advocate Sreedhar Pottaraju brought to the notice of the Bench that a petition had been filed on behalf of the families of police personnel allegedly assaulted during the July 20 Parliament march.

Senior advocate Vikas Singh urged the court to frame uniform guidelines governing police action during protests, pointing out that allegations of police excesses had surfaced across the country.

Noting that the issues raised extended beyond any single State, the CJI said all pending petitions would be heard together on Tuesday.

Gig workers still await Ayushman Bharat cover; over 10 lakh register on e-Shram portal

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Thirty-year-old Shiv Kumar, a gig worker with a quick commerce platform that delivers groceries, vegetables and other daily essentials, has been struggling to repay the loan he took to meet the expenses of his child's delivery. He still owes ₹50,000 to a friend. Like many gig workers, Kumar has not been provided health insurance coverage under the Ayushman Bharat scheme, despite the Union Budget 2025-26 announcing such a benefit. Although he registered on the e-Shram portal, he is yet to receive any health coverage.

"With my salary of ₹30,000, how can I think of buying insurance from a private company? If the government gives us something, it will be helpful," he said.

More than a year after the Budget 2025-26 promised

health insurance under Ayushman Bharat for one crore gig and platform workers, the scheme is yet to be rolled out. While the Centre has begun registering workers on the e-Shram portal and says implementation is underway, gig workers have not started receiving healthcare benefits under the Ayushman Bharat-Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY).

Presenting the Union Budget in February 2025, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman announced that one crore gig workers would be brought under the Ayushman Bharat scheme. However, despite the announcement and subsequent registration drives, the government has not specified a timeline for extending the promised health coverage.

According to Dharamendra Kumar, Founding Secretary of Jan Pahal, an organisation that advocates for gig workers, discussions

have taken place with the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) on extending provident fund benefits to gig workers and with the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) on linking workers to pension schemes.

"Data of more than 10 lakh gig workers has already been collected through the e-Shram portal, but there has been no policy movement on Ayushman Bharat after that," Kumar said.

1.2 CRORE WORKERS

According to the Economic Survey 2025-26, India has around 1.2 crore gig workers. The survey noted that the gig economy, including delivery services, ride-hailing and freelancing, has witnessed rapid structural growth, transforming informal employment into more organised, platform-driven work.

The number of gig workers has increased by 55 per cent from 77 lakh in FY21 to



ON THE RISE. The number of gig workers has increased by 55 per cent, from 77 lakh in FY21 to 1.2 crore in FY25 **RAJUV**

1.2 crore in FY25, driven by smartphone penetration of over 80 crore users and nearly 15 billion UPI transactions every month. The sector now accounts for more than 2 per cent of India's workforce, with growth outpacing overall employment. Non-agricultural gig work is projected to make up 6.7 per cent of the workforce by 2029-30, contributing an estimated ₹2.35 lakh crore to the country's GDP, the Sur-

vey said. Government sources said that under the Code on Social Security, state-level social security boards will be constituted to decide the implementation of welfare measures, including Ayushman Bharat coverage for gig workers. However, they acknowledged that no concrete discussions have yet taken place on rolling out the scheme.

In a recent reply to a starred question by BJP MP

PC Mohan in the Lok Sabha, Labour and Employment Minister Mansukh Mandaviya said health coverage under AB-PMJAY for gig and platform workers would be delivered through the e-Shram portal. As of July 14, 2026, more than 10.65 lakh platform workers had registered on the portal.

NO TIMELINE

The Minister said the Union Budget 2025-26 had announced registration of platform workers on the e-Shram portal, issuance of identity cards and extension of healthcare benefits under AB-PMJAY. However, he did not provide a timeline for the rollout of the health insurance scheme.

According to the government, the e-Shram portal has been developed as a one-stop platform by integrating multiple social security and welfare schemes. Registered workers, including gig and platform workers, will be

able to access welfare benefits, including AB-PMJAY, and track benefits received through the portal.

To facilitate enrolment, the government launched a dedicated Aggregator Module on December 12, 2024, enabling digital platforms to onboard workers onto the e-Shram portal. So far, 21 aggregators, including Zomato, Blinkit, Swiggy, Ola, Uber, Rapido, Amazon, Porter, Urban Company and Flipkart, have joined the platform. APIs have also been developed to enable worker verification and sharing of worker data by aggregators.

REGISTRATION DRIVE

A simplified registration module for platform workers was introduced on March 12, 2025, allowing workers to self-register or update their occupation if they were already enrolled on e-Shram. The Labour Ministry also conducted nationwide registration drives in April, May

and August-September 2025 in collaboration with states and Union Territories to increase enrolment.

The government's reply comes after the Code on Social Security, 2020, came into force on November 21, 2025, formally recognising gig and platform workers for the first time under Indian law. The Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026, notified on May 8, operationalised these provisions by mandating worker registration, requiring aggregators to share worker data electronically and prescribing eligibility criteria for social security benefits.

The Centre said it has held multiple rounds of consultations with aggregators, worker associations, state governments and other stakeholders to develop a comprehensive social security framework for gig and platform workers, including implementation of welfare schemes under the Code.

